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THE COUNTERFEIT COMMONS · THE SECOND FORGERY · KLEPTOPOIESIS · FIDUCIARY EROS ·



Abstract

This dissertation argues that Park Chan-wook's *The Handmaiden* (*Agassi*, 2016), co-written with Chung Seo-kyung and transposed from Sarah Waters's neo-Victorian novel *Fingersmith* (2002) to Korea under Japanese rule in the 1930s, is a philosophical machine whose operations exceed the three frames in which it has principally been received: the lesbian costume romance, the anticolonial allegory, and the metacinematic critique of the male gaze. Read contrapuntally across four genealogies—the Female Gothic and its wrongful-confinement plot (Radcliffe, Wollstonecraft, Collins, *Gaslight*, Hitchcock, Kim Ki-young); the Sadean apparatus of the narrating woman and its Japanese modernist rhymes (Sade, Pasolini, Tanizaki, Edogawa Ranpo, Itō Seiu, Ōshima); the discourse of colonial mimicry (Fanon, Bhabha, Fukuzawa); and the convergent archives of feminist, queer, and humanist thought from Montaigne and La Boétie through Wollstonecraft, Woolf, Beauvoir, Irigaray, Cixous, Wittig, Sedgwick, Spivak, and Arendt, with Mencius, the Korean Four–Seven Debate, and Donghak as East Asian interlocutors—the film emerges as the diagnosis of a world in which every guarantor of value has been counterfeited. Genealogy, nationality, aristocratic title, authorship, the rare book, virginity, sanity, and the proper name are all forged within its diegesis, and the forgeries are homologous in Jean-Joseph Goux's sense: each is a general equivalent, and their simultaneous insolvency is the film's true subject.

The central claim is that *The Handmaiden* answers this diagnosis neither with a nostalgic return to authenticity—nation, nature, true self, maternal origin—nor with postmodern resignation to the simulacrum, but with what I term **the second forgery**: a counterfeiting of the counterfeit, executed by subjects who steal and refunction the apparatuses of their own subjection, and whose truth is guaranteed not by origin but by mutual trust. Three original concepts organize the argument. **Kleptopoiesis** names the making of a form of life through the theft of scripts, names, erotic techniques, languages, and capital, extending Cixous's double sense of *voler* (to steal, to fly), de Certeau's poaching, and Benjamin's refunctioning. **Fiduciary eros** names a regime of

truth in which value is backed by promise and forgiveness (Arendt) and by fidelity to an event (Badiou) rather than by the gold standard of descent; the film's period, coincident with the abandonment of the gold standard by Britain and Japan in 1931, renders this substitution historically legible. **The counterfeit commons** names the social space opened by those without legitimate origin: the colonized, the orphan, the servant, the thief, the lesbian. Together these disclose a **post-genealogical humanism**, grounded in election rather than descent, which explains the adaptation's most consequential infidelity—Park's excision of Waters's maternal birth-secret.

The dissertation further demonstrates that the film relocates the sensory ground of emancipation from the scopic (Mulvey) and the scriptural-phonic (Derrida, Silverman) to the haptic and the sonic. Its closing image converts pornography's frenzy of the visible (Comolli, Williams) into a **frenzy of the audible**, and answers the bell tolled over the substituted woman's body at the end of Hitchcock's *Vertigo* with bells rung in shared, unwitnessed pleasure. The study contributes to film-philosophy, adaptation studies, transnational feminist and queer theory, postcolonial Korean and Japanese studies, and the comparative history of humanism.



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On the seals. Each opening is stamped with a seal in cinnabar. Chapter and part numbers are cut in the formal numerals (갖은자 in Korean, *daiji* in Japanese) that East Asian banknotes, cheques, and contracts use because they resist alteration: 壹 for one, 貳 for two, 參 for three. The front and back matter carry single characters: 要 (essentials) for the abstract, 目 (contents), 序 (introduction), 結 (conclusion), 語 (words), 書 (books), and 鍵 (key). The line-work on the cover and part titles borrows the guilloché that security printers engrave against counterfeiting, and the cover's serial numbers record 1931, the year Britain and Japan left the gold standard, and 2016, the year of the film.



Introduction

The Problem of the Counterfeit Origin

> *He hath put down the mighty from their seats, and exalted them of low degree.*
>
> — Luke 1:52, King James Version

> *Parce que c'était lui ; parce que c'était moi.*
>
> — Michel de Montaigne, "De l'amitié," *Essais* I.28

I A World Without Originals

Nothing of value in *The Handmaiden* is what it claims to be. Kouzuki, master of the estate, is a Korean who has purchased Japanese standing through marriage and who professes to find his own nation ugly and Japan beautiful. His celebrated library is the showroom of a forgery workshop: its rare erotic editions are counterfeited and sold to collectors whose bids are raised by the recited voice of his ward. Count Fujiwara is a Korean swindler whose title is a costume. Sook-hee, the pickpocket installed as the heiress's maid, works under the Japanese name Tamako. The wedding at the center of the plot is never consummated, and the blood on its sheet is counterfeit. A madness is manufactured, certified, and enforced. An inheritance passes by fraud. Even the film's Japanese, spoken by a predominantly Korean cast, is audibly accented—an imperial language uttered at one remove from itself.

The question this dissertation poses follows from that inventory. What can emancipation mean in a world in which the origins to which emancipation customarily appeals have themselves been forged? Each dominant modern grammar of liberation presupposes an uncounterfeited ground. Liberalism presupposes a human nature bearing rights; Marxism, a labor whose value is real before it is alienated; anticolonial nationalism, an authentic national self occluded by the occupier; one strand of feminism, a female body, a maternal semiotic, or a women's culture prior to patriarchal inscription; classical

humanism, a dignity rooted in reason or species-being. *The Handmaiden* evacuates every one of these grounds. Yet it ends neither in nihilism nor in the vengeance that structures most of its director's oeuvre, but in the most unambiguously consummated happy ending Park Chan-wook has filmed. The task of this thesis is to explain how a work that abolishes the authentic arrives at joy, and to name the philosophy that the explanation discloses.

II The Object

Park adapted Waters's novel with Chung Seo-kyung, his co-writer since *Lady Vengeance* (2005). The film premiered in competition at Cannes in May 2016, where Ryu Seong-hie's production design received the Vulcan Award of the Technical Artist, and it later won the BAFTA for Film Not in the English Language. Its transposition is systematic. Victorian London becomes colonial Korea. Waters's country house, Briar, becomes an estate fusing an English manor with a Japanese residence. Mr Christopher Lilly's lifelong bibliography of erotica, modeled on the Victorian bibliographer Henry Spencer Ashbee, becomes Kouzuki's counterfeiting enterprise. The baby-farming household of the Borough becomes a Korean den of thieves that traffics infants to Japanese families.

The film is divided into three parts. Part One is focalized through Sook-hee. Fujiwara recruits the young thief to serve as maid to Lady Hideko, a Japanese heiress raised by an uncle-by-marriage who intends to marry her for her fortune. Sook-hee is to help the Count seduce and marry Hideko and then commit her to an asylum. Instead she falls in love with her mark, and the part closes as Sook-hee herself is dragged into the asylum under the Countess's name. Part Two, focalized through Hideko, returns to her childhood. From girlhood Kouzuki made her read pornography aloud to gatherings of adult men, correcting her delivery and punishing her in his basement when she disobeyed: the sexual exploitation of a child, conducted as connoisseurship. Her aunt, made to perform the same readings before her, was found hanged from a tree in the garden, a death Kouzuki called madness. Part Two then recounts the pact by which Hideko and Fujiwara chose a maid to be committed in her place. It replays the first part's scenes from the other side of the con, discloses Hideko's reciprocated love, and culminates in an interrupted hanging, a mutual confession, and the women's destruction of the library. Part Three executes the women's counterplot. Sook-hee is freed from the asylum; Hideko drugs and abandons the Count; Kouzuki captures Fujiwara and cuts off his fingers in the basement, and Fujiwara kills himself and his captor with mercury-laced cigarettes; the women sail for Shanghai.

III State of the Question

Criticism has clustered around three axes. Adaptation and neo-Victorian studies have treated the film as a transposition, measuring its departures from Waters within the post-fidelity paradigm of Hutcheon (2006), Stam (2000), and Genette's typology of hypertextuality (1982). Feminist and queer criticism has debated whether the film's explicit sexuality reproduces or dismantles the male gaze it thematizes, frequently by comparison with Abdellatif Kechiche's *Blue Is the Warmest Color* (2013). Postcolonial and historicist criticism has read the film within South Korea's cycle of colonial-period cinema, the politics of collaboration, and the contested memory of Japanese rule.

Each axis isolates one register of the film's counterfeits—the textual, the sexual, the national—and treats the others as context. The premise of this thesis is that their homology is the object. Jean-Joseph Goux has shown that gold, the father, the phallus, the monarch, and language operate in modernity as structurally homologous general equivalents, each a privileged term set apart to measure all others (Goux 1973; 1984). *The Handmaiden* counterfeits every one of them at once. The fortune passes by fraud. The guardian-uncle is a would-be husband. The phallus is reduced to Kouzuki's impotent auditory voyeurism and to Fujiwara's final, useless boast that he dies with his genitals intact. The sovereign is mimicked by a collaborator and impersonated by a swindler. Language is forged in the library and accented in the mouth. The film's subject is not one crisis but the simultaneous insolvency of all the guarantors.

IV Method and Corpus

The method is contrapuntal in Edward Said's sense: the metropolitan text is read together with the colonial history it presupposes and suppresses (Said 1993). Park's adaptation is itself a contrapuntal act. Said found the wealth of Austen's *Mansfield Park* silently sustained by an Antiguan plantation; Park relocates the English country house into the colony and makes the ground visible. The method is also comparative without hierarchy, placing European, Korean, Japanese, and Chinese thought on a single plane. It is film-philosophical in Stanley Cavell's sense, treating the film not as an illustration of theory but as a site of thinking (Cavell 1971). Its interpretive temper moves, as the film does, from the symptomatic reading of Althusser and Jameson (Althusser and Balibar 1965; Jameson 1981) toward the reparative reading of Sedgwick (2003).

Three tiers of originator are distinguished. The first comprises attested or textually manifest sources: Waters, and through Waters the sensation fiction of

Wilkie Collins; Sade; Japanese shunga, above all Hokusai; Hitchcock, especially *Vertigo*, which Park has repeatedly named as formative; and Kim Ki-young's *The Housemaid*. The second comprises the genealogical ancestors of those sources, among them Radcliffe, Wollstonecraft, Dickens, and Laclos. The third comprises elective affinities: thinkers whose relevance is structural rather than causal. The distinction is a matter of method. This thesis does not claim that Park read Irigaray; it claims that the film thinks what Irigaray thought, and then thinks further.

Korean is romanized according to the Revised Romanization and Japanese according to modified Hepburn; East Asian names appear family name first except where another usage is established. Because subtitle translations vary across releases, the film's dialogue is paraphrased rather than quoted, and references are to its three parts.

V Thesis

The argument advances six propositions.

1. *The Handmaiden* depicts a regime of the counterfeit in which colonial mimicry, the patriarchal traffic in women, and the pornographic archive form a single economy governed by the fungibility of persons.
2. The film rejects the restoration of origin as an emancipatory strategy. Its decisive adaptive act, the excision of Waters's maternal birth-secret, removes the genre's final appeal to genealogical truth.
3. Its heroines emancipate themselves through **kleptopoiesis**: the theft and refunctioning of the very apparatuses—scripts, names, plots, erotic instruments, languages, capital—that produced their subjection.
4. The truth their bond produces is **fiduciary** rather than referential, backed by promise, forgiveness, and fidelity rather than by origin, as money after 1931 is backed by trust rather than metal. Its product is **the second forgery**, a counterfeit that knows itself as such and is for that reason the only honest thing in the film.
5. This bond opens a **counterfeit commons** and discloses a **post-genealogical humanism**, in which dignity is minted through election rather than inherited through descent.
6. The film relocates the sensory ground of emancipation from the eye and the written word to the hand and the ringing bell, converting the frenzy of the visible into a **frenzy of the audible**.

VI Architecture

Part I (Chapters 1–3) reconstructs the film's genealogies: the Female Gothic and the wrongful-confinement plot; the Sadean apparatus and its Japanese modernist rhymes; and the colonial grammar of mimicry. Part II (Chapters 4–11) analyzes the film's core philosophical operations: the library as patriarchal archive; the regimes of gaze and voice; the epistemology of touch; the reversal of the traffic in women; the dialectic of narration and recognition; the logic of copies without originals; the ethics of destroying an archive; and the topology of flight. Part III (Chapters 12–15) constructs the synthetic theory—kleptopoiesis, fiduciary eros, the counterfeit commons, and post-genealogical humanism—and tests it against the strongest objections. The Conclusion reads the film's final image against the ending of *Vertigo*.



Part One

Genealogies

Part I reconstructs the three lineages that *The Handmaiden* condenses: the Gothic-sensational plot of wrongful confinement, the libertine apparatus that converts a woman's voice into erotic capital, and the colonial grammar of mimicry. Each chapter identifies originators and shows what the film retains, inverts, or excises.

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Chapter 1

From Udolpho to Gyeongseong

The Female Gothic and the Plot of Wrongful Confinement

1.1 The Radcliffean template

The backstory of *The Handmaiden* reproduces, almost diagrammatically, the property plot of Ann Radcliffe's *The Mysteries of Udolpho* (1794). Emily St. Aubert's aunt, Madame Cheron, marries the adventurer Montoni, who carries her to his Apennine fortress and attempts to extort her estates; she dies under his regime, and his designs pass to her niece. Park's Kouzuki marries Hideko's aunt to acquire Japanese standing and wealth; the aunt dies within his house; his designs pass to the niece, whom he means to marry. The Female Gothic, as Ellen Moers named it (1976), renders the legal enclosure of women under coverture as architectural enclosure. Its heroine traverses corridors, locked chambers, and vaults, and her flight through the building figures flight from a property regime that made her both owner and owned.

Radcliffe's explained supernatural supplies a further anticipation. The horror concealed behind the black veil at Udolpho proves to be a wax effigy of a decaying body. Kouzuki's wooden mannequin, positioned in the library's demonstrations where a woman's body ought to be, belongs to the same order of simulacral bodies, which terrify because they replace persons.

1.2 Wollstonecraft's *Maria*: the radical kernel

The decisive ancestor is Mary Wollstonecraft's unfinished novel *The Wrongs of Woman, or Maria* (1798), in which the Gothic is converted into political philosophy. Maria is confined in a private madhouse by her husband, George Venables, who seeks control of her fortune, and the asylum is revealed as the hidden truth of marriage under coverture. Her keeper, Jemima, is a working-class woman whose history Wollstonecraft narrates at length: born illegitimate, raped as a servant girl by her master, turned out when she became pregnant, and driven into prostitution and theft. The novel's central alliance is

cross-class: the lady and the criminal woman recognize in each other a single condition differently distributed. Among the fragmentary conclusions left at Wollstonecraft's death, one stages Maria's attempted suicide by laudanum, interrupted when Jemima returns with the daughter Maria believed dead.

The Handmaiden restores, after two centuries of generic attenuation, this Wollstonecraftian kernel: the lady and the thief, the asylum as marriage's instrument, the suicide interrupted by the lower-class woman. It makes one alteration, and the alteration is philosophically decisive. Jemima saves Maria by restoring a child; Sook-hee saves Hideko by offering herself. The reason to live is relocated from genealogy to election, from the maternal bond to the erotic one. Chapter 13 argues that this substitution is the hinge of the film's post-genealogical humanism.

1.3 Sensation, substitution, and the lunacy panic

Between Wollstonecraft and Waters stands the sensation novel of the 1860s, whose anxieties were not fictional. In 1858 Rosina Bulwer-Lytton was consigned to a private asylum by her husband after publicly denouncing him, and was released only after public outcry. In 1860 Elizabeth Packard was committed in Illinois by her husband, a minister, and later campaigned for the reform of commitment law. Elaine Showalter (1985) has reconstructed how such cases converted psychiatric confinement into a cultural nightmare of wives disappeared by husbands.

Wilkie Collins's *The Woman in White* (1859–60) supplies the substitution mechanism on which Waters, and then Park, built. Sir Percival Glyde and Count Fosco exploit the resemblance between the heiress Laura Fairlie and the asylum fugitive Anne Catherick: Anne's death is registered as Laura's, and Laura is confined under Anne's name. The plot's motor is fungibility, one woman administratively exchangeable for another, and its villainous intelligence is a foreign Count whose title is theater. Fosco is the ancestor of Fujiwara. D. A. Miller (1988) showed that Collins's novel locates its suspense in the reader's nervous body and its menace in the contagion of gender categories, from the mannish Marian Halcombe to the effeminate Fosco. Mary Elizabeth Braddon's *Lady Audley's Secret* (1862), whose heroine forges her own identity and is consigned to a Belgian maison de santé, and Charles Reade's *Hard Cash* (1863) complete the field. Sensation fiction knew what Wollstonecraft knew—that the asylum is a property instrument—but it typically returned the confined woman to marriage through a male rescuer, of whom Walter Hartright is the paradigm.

1.4 The den: from Fagin to the infant trade

Dickens's *Oliver Twist* (1837–39) supplied Waters with the thieves' household that raises children as instruments of theft. Waters's Lant Street, where Mrs Sucksby farms infants, draws on the Victorian baby-farming scandals, in which women paid to take in unwanted infants let them die or killed them: Margaret Waters was hanged for such a killing in 1870, and Amelia Dyer, who murdered infants in her care over many years, was hanged in 1896. Park transposes the den into an infant-trafficking household that sends Korean babies to Japanese families. The transposition converts a metropolitan scandal of domestic economy into an image of colonial extraction, in which the colonized body is exported at birth. It also prefigures, at a distance of decades, the postwar history in which South Korea became one of the largest sources of children for transnational adoption (Kim 2010; Oh 2015).

1.5 Waters: the lesbian neo-Victorian and the birth-secret

Waters wrote *Fingersmith* (2002) after doctoral research on lesbian and gay historical fiction (Waters 1995). The novel belongs to a neo-Victorian project, in Heilmann and Llewellyn's sense (2010), of excavating the sexualities that the Victorian archive both produced and concealed. Her preceding novel, *Affinity* (1999), ends with a maid, Ruth Vigers, and a spiritualist medium, Selina Dawes, defrauding the lady who loved the medium: the lesbian con as betrayal. *Fingersmith* converts betrayal into love, but it retains the sensation genre's ultimate guarantee, the birth-secret. Mrs Sucksby is revealed as Maud's mother; the infants were exchanged; identity is resolved by disclosure of origin. Waters's title encodes this double structure. In older slang a fingersmith is both a thief and a midwife: an agent of appropriation and an agent of birth.

Park keeps the thief and excises the midwife. The film contains no exchanged infants and no maternal revelation, and the den's matriarch remains a surrogate rather than a secret mother. This is the adaptation's most consequential infidelity. The sensation novel's final court of appeal—who one really is by birth—is abolished, and identity is left to be made rather than discovered.

1.6 The cinematic Gothic: *Gaslight*, Hitchcock, and the unknown woman

The film's cinematic ancestry runs through the Gothic melodrama of the 1940s. In George Cukor's *Gaslight* (1944), adapted from Patrick Hamilton's play *Gas Light* (1938), a young woman inherits the London house in which her aunt, a celebrated singer, was murdered years before. Her husband, the murderer, has married her in order to search the house for the aunt's jewels, and he

manufactures her madness so that she can be confined. The parallels are structural: a dead aunt whose value was her voice; a niece who inherits house, voice, and danger; a husband who requires the niece's insanity to reach a fortune. Cavell (1996) places *Gaslight* among the melodramas of the unknown woman, a genre in which a woman achieves selfhood not through marriage but through refusing its terms.

Hitchcock contributes three templates. *Rebecca* (1940) supplies the housekeeper who serves a dead mistress and the great house that burns. *Marnie* (1964) supplies the woman thief blackmailed into marriage, and the honeymoon ship on which her husband, Mark Rutland, rapes her and she attempts to drown herself. *Vertigo* (1958) supplies the substitution plot in its purest cinematic form. Gavin Elster employs a working-class woman, Judy, to impersonate his wealthy wife so that a murder may pass as a suicide driven by inherited madness. Scottie's later remaking of Judy into the dead Madeleine is the cinema's most lucid allegory of the male gaze as necrophilic pedagogy. *The Handmaiden* is, among other things, a rewriting of *Vertigo* in which the substituted woman and the lady she replaces turn toward each other and away from the men who designed their interchangeability. The Conclusion returns to the bell tower.

1.7 The Korean Gothic: the housemaid and the voice

Two Korean films complete the lineage. Kim Ki-young's *The Housemaid* (*Hanyeo*, 1960), refashioned by Im Sang-soo in 2010, makes the domestic servant the uncanny return of everything the bourgeois household of compressed modernity has excluded (Chang 2010). The maid seduces the father, poisons the family, and turns the staircase into an axis of terror. Im Kwon-taek's *Seopyeonje* (1993), the canonical cinematic meditation on *han*, gives Korean cinema its most indelible image of a patriarch cultivating a woman's voice through injury: a father blinds his adopted daughter to deepen the sorrow in her *pansori*. Park's film answers both. The maid does not destroy the household by seducing its master; she abandons it with its daughter. The woman whose voice was perfected through cruelty does not consecrate her suffering as art; she refuses her trainer.

1.8 Synthesis

Across this genealogy one structure holds constant: a woman's property, voice, and sanity form a single object of male appropriation. What varies is the means of escape—providence in Radcliffe, cross-class friendship in Wollstonecraft, the male rescuer in Collins, death in *Vertigo*, a husband's therapy in *Marnie*, the art

of suffering in *Seopyeonje*. Park's innovation is to locate the escape in the conspiratorial love of the two women whom the plot had designed to be interchangeable. The instrument of their subjection, substitutability, becomes the condition of their encounter.



Chapter 2

The Historienne and the Basement

The Sadean Apparatus and Its Japanese Rhymes

2.1 The narrating woman

The reading sessions at the center of Kouzuki's household reconstitute an apparatus first assembled by the Marquis de Sade in *The 120 Days of Sodom*, composed in the Bastille in 1785. Four libertines seclude themselves in the castle of Silling with captives they have abducted, among them eight girls and eight boys aged twelve to fifteen. Four aging storytellers—Duclos, Champville, Martaine, and Desgranges—narrate six hundred passions in four graded series that escalate to torture and murder, and the libertines enact on the captives what the narratives describe. The *historienne* is the apparatus's indispensable and paradoxical figure. She is a woman whose voice is the libertines' instrument; her narration is a commodity in the economy of their pleasure; and her expertise supplies the program by which the captives, children among them, are raped, tortured, and in many cases killed.

Kouzuki's institution reproduces each element. A woman's trained and corrected voice narrates to a circle of men; the narration raises the price of the books it performs; and its content is occasionally demonstrated, with ropes and a wooden mannequin, as a program for action. Kouzuki's innovation is to fuse narrator and victim. Sade's *historiennes* are aged and spared, their bodies exempt from the passions they recount. Hideko is a child when Kouzuki begins making her read pornography aloud to adult men, so that the narrator is herself the child the narrative threatens: what the household calls training is the sexual exploitation of a child, administered as connoisseurship. The aunt who preceded her, and whose death she inherits, marks the place where the *historienne* becomes the victim.

2.2 Salò and the political transposition of Sade

Pier Paolo Pasolini's *Salò, or the 120 Days of Sodom* (1975) transposed Sade to the Republic of Salò, the Nazi puppet state of 1943–45, and thereby argued that fascism is libertinage administered by the state, an anarchy of power that legalizes its own atrocities. Pasolini's *historiennes* are bourgeois women in evening dress, attended by a pianist; their narratives are the protocol of the Duke, the Bishop, the Magistrate, and the President, who have fascist militiamen round up eighteen adolescents, nine girls and nine boys, subject them to rape and degradation, and in the final sequence torture and kill many of them. Park performs the homologous transposition. The Sadean apparatus is relocated to the collaborationist household of Japan's colonial empire, and its spectators are collectors under imperial rule.

The difference lies in the endings. *Salò* closes with two young guards dancing together awkwardly while, in the courtyard below, the libertines torture and kill captives: a fragile and ambiguous tenderness inside the apparatus. *The Handmaiden* closes after the apparatus has destroyed itself, with tenderness outside it. In this precise sense it is an **anti-Salò**: the Sadean machine is described in full, and then its narrator walks out of it.

2.3 Scheherazade, Barthes, and the grammar of eros

The *historienne* has an older sister in Scheherazade, who narrates to defer her own execution and so converts narrative into time and cunning into survival. Hideko's reading also defers, keeping her from the basement, but the film adds a further turn: narration becomes the training ground for a plan. Roland Barthes read Sade as a *logothete*, the founder of a language whose eroticism is a combinatory grammar of positions, figures, and sequences (Barthes 1971). Kouzuki's erotics are grammatical in exactly this sense. He corrects intonation and pacing, interrupts misplaced emphasis, and treats the woman's voice as the phonetic realization of a syntax he owns. His pleasure lies in correct pronunciation.

2.4 Institution and contract: Deleuze

Gilles Deleuze's *Coldness and Cruelty* (*Présentation de Sacher-Masoch*, 1967) distinguishes the Sadean from the masochian on formal grounds. Sadism requires institutions, proceeds by demonstration, and aims at a cold, impersonal law; masochism proceeds by contract, persuasion, and suspense, binding the torturer through a negotiated agreement. Kouzuki's library is a Sadean institution: impersonal, demonstrative, legislated by its master. The women's relation passes through a sequence of contracts—Fujiwara's

employment of Sook-hee, Hideko's pact with Fujiwara—before arriving at a third form that is neither Sadean nor masochian. It is a promise between equals, the subject of Chapter 8.

2.5 Bataille, Carter, Réage, Laclos

For Georges Bataille, eroticism is the transgression that confirms the taboo it violates (Bataille 1957). Kouzuki's library is a machine of regulated transgression, a space where the forbidden is recited under conditions that reinforce the hierarchy permitting its recitation. Angela Carter's *The Sadeian Woman* (1978) read Sade's paired heroines, Justine and Juliette, as the two destinies available to women in his universe: the masochism of virtue and the predation of reason. Carter proposed a moral pornographer who might use pornography to criticize existing relations between the sexes. Hideko is a third Sadeian woman, neither victim nor predator: the narrator who turns. Carter's "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) supplies the Gothic setting of this turning—a Marquis's library of erotica, a forbidden room, a bride initiated through reading. In Carter's tale the rescuer is the bride's mother, who rides in to kill the Marquis. In Park's film rescue comes laterally, from the lover, rather than vertically, from the parent.

Pauline Réage's *Story of O* (1954) presents the château of Roissy as a school of submission, and Jessica Benjamin read O's progressive self-abandonment as a desperate quest for recognition through domination (J. Benjamin 1988). Choderlos de Laclos supplies the inverse figure. In Letter 81 of *Les Liaisons dangereuses* (1782), the Marquise de Merteuil narrates her self-education in dissimulation: the mastery of her face, the study of moralists and novelists, the conversion of observation into power. Kouzuki's abuse, which he conducts as a pedagogy designed to produce an O, inadvertently produces a Merteuil, a woman who has learned to make her face unreadable. The difference matters: Merteuil chose her schooling, while Hideko's was forced on her as a child. Unlike Merteuil, Hideko is not punished by her narrative.

2.6 Ars erotica as commodity

Michel Foucault contrasted the Western *scientia sexualis*, which extracts the truth of sex through confession and classification, with an *ars erotica*, which he located in China, Japan, India, Rome, and Arab-Muslim societies, and which transmits the secret knowledge of pleasure from master to disciple (Foucault 1976). Kouzuki's library collapses the distinction. A Korean collaborator industrializes an Asian *ars erotica* into a Western-style enterprise of cataloguing, pricing, and forgery, and stages its transmission as a market. The library is thus an instance

of auto-orientalism: the colonized subject performing from within the very binary through which the West exoticized Asian sexuality.

2.7 Japanese rhymes: shunga, kinbaku, ero-guro

The octopus kept in Kouzuki's basement tank invokes Katsushika Hokusai's print of a woman diver in a sexual encounter with two octopuses, popularly known as *The Dream of the Fisherman's Wife*, from the album *Kinoe no komatsu* (1814). The image's reception has oscillated between readings of violation and readings of female pleasure. Its captivity in a tank—an image become a specimen, kept for terror—figures the library's transformation of an ambiguous erotic art into an instrument of domination. Timon Screech (1999) insisted that shunga were made to be used, as aids to arousal, rather than contemplated as objects of connoisseurship. Kouzuki inverts this history, converting use-value into exchange-value.

The suspended demonstrations in the library evoke the kinbaku aesthetics given modern form by Itō Seiu (1882–1961), whose rope studies and torture pictures belong to precisely the period in which the film is set. That period is also the moment of *ero-guro-nansensu*, the erotic grotesque nonsense of late-1920s and early-1930s Japanese mass culture analyzed by Miriam Silverberg (2006). Its literature furnishes the basement. In Edogawa Ranpo's "The Human Chair" (1925), a craftsman hides inside an armchair to feel the bodies of the women who sit on it, a haptic voyeurism. In "The Caterpillar" (1929), a wife tends a limbless veteran. In *Strange Tale of Panorama Island* (1926–27), an impostor assumes a dead millionaire's identity and spends the fortune on an erotic-grotesque paradise. Yumeno Kyūsaku's *Dogra Magra* (1935) sets its labyrinth of identity inside a psychiatric ward.

2.8 Tanizaki, Kawabata, Ōshima

Tanizaki Jun'ichirō is the film's richest Japanese elective affinity. In *Naomi* (*Chijin no ai*, 1924–25), Jōji undertakes a Pygmalion project, molding a café waitress into a Westernized modern girl until she masters him. Kouzuki's molding of Hideko into a voice for a hybrid Western-Japanese canon is the same project, with the same unintended result. In *Manji* (1928–30), filmed by Masumura Yasuzō in 1964, a passion between two women, Sonoko and Mitsuko, is entangled with an impotent male partner who extracts written oaths sealed in blood: the lesbian bond captured by a man's contract. In *The Key* (1956), spouses conduct their erotic war through diaries written to be stolen and read. *In Praise of Shadows* (1933) elaborates an aesthetic of lacquer, obscurity, and the half-visible female body against Western illumination. Park's

library, in which the reader's face glows from darkness above a lacquered stage, is a Tanizakian interior turned to industrial use. Kawabata Yasunari's *House of the Sleeping Beauties* (1961), in which old men pay to lie beside drugged girls, describes the gentlemen's audience exactly: a desire that requires the woman's agency to be absent.

Ōshima Nagisa's *In the Realm of the Senses* (1976) dramatizes the Sada Abe incident of 1936, in which a woman strangled her lover and severed his genitals, and it frames the lovers' erotic withdrawal against the march of militarism outside. Fujiwara's final boast, that he at least dies with his genitals intact, reads as Park's ironic citation of Sada Abe. Castration has been displaced onto the fingers, Freud's classic substitute, and the preserved organ is all that remains of a masculinity whose instruments—the hands that paint, swindle, and caress—have been taken.

2.9 Synthesis

The Sadean apparatus and its Japanese rhymes share a single architecture: the woman's voice and body as text, men as readers, a pedagogy of correction, and a basement. Park's originality lies in embedding this architecture within a colonial economy, where books are commodities sold to collaborators and colonizers, and in having it dismantled from within by its narrator in alliance with a servant who stands outside its canon.



Chapter 3

Mimic Men

Colonial Modernity and the Grammar of Passing

3.1 Kouzuki and the desire to become the colonizer

Kouzuki is the film's most complete portrait of the colonized subject who wishes to become the colonizer. Born Korean, he acquires Japanese status by marrying into a Japanese family, adopts its cultural forms with a convert's zeal, and declares his own nation ugly and Japan beautiful. Frantz Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952) anatomized the colonized subject's desire to be white, the internalization of the colonizer's gaze as self-contempt. Kouzuki's Japaneseness is that internalized gaze made into a household. Homi Bhabha's "Of Mimicry and Man" (1984) adds the crucial ambivalence. Colonial mimicry produces a subject who is almost the same but not quite, and the difference both secures and menaces colonial authority, since a resemblance that can be learned exposes the colonizer's identity as performance. V. S. Naipaul's *The Mimic Men* (1967) gave the figure its novelistic form.

The film distributes Bhabha's ambivalence between two men. Kouzuki's mimicry is sincere, and it menaces nothing but himself: mimicry as servitude. Fujiwara's mimicry is cynical, and it is a weapon: a Korean who impersonates a Japanese aristocrat in order to carry off the fortune that a Korean impersonating a Japanese gentleman had reserved for himself. The two meet in the basement as each other's truth. Each is a counterfeit Japanese, and they die together in a cellar, of the Count's mercury, after the uncle's cutter has taken the Count's fingers.

3.2 Double mimicry and the Anglo-Japanese house

Kouzuki's mimicry has a second order, because the Japan he imitates was itself imitating Europe. Fukuzawa Yukichi's editorial "On Leaving Asia" ("Datsu-A ron," 1885) urged Japan to quit the company of its neighbors and take its place among the nations of the West; the later slogan *datsu-a nyū-ō*, leave Asia and

enter Europe, named the program of Meiji modernity. Kouzuki's estate, which fuses an English manor with a Japanese residence, is that program in architecture. I call this **double mimicry**: a Korean mimicking a Japan that mimics Britain.

The fusion has a precise diplomatic referent. The Anglo-Japanese Alliance of 1902, renewed in 1905, saw Britain acknowledge Japan's paramount interests in Korea. In the same year the Taft–Katsura memorandum recorded American acquiescence, the protectorate treaty stripped Korea of its diplomatic sovereignty, and annexation followed in 1910. The English wing and the Japanese wing standing together on Korean soil are the alliance that delivered Korea to Japan, built in timber and stone, with a Korean collaborator as its curator. Colonial Seoul was itself a palimpsest of this kind. In Deoksugung palace the Western-style Seokjojeon hall, designed by a British architect, was completed in the year of annexation. In 1926 the Japanese Government-General Building rose before Gyeongbokgung, screening the Joseon throne hall behind an imperial façade; it was demolished only in 1995–96.

Stefan Tanaka (1993) has shown that modern Japanese historiography constructed *tōyō*, the Orient, as Japan's own past and as the space Japan was destined to lead. Korea became Japan's Orient. Kouzuki's contempt for his nation is this second-order orientalism internalized: the colonized man regarding Korea through the eyes of a Japan that regarded Asia through the eyes of Europe.

3.3 Naisen ittai, sōshi-kaimei, and the renaming of Sook-hee

In the later 1930s the Government-General intensified assimilation under the slogan *naisen ittai*, Japan and Korea as one body, and the program of *kōminka*, the transformation of Koreans into imperial subjects. The 1939 ordinance on family names, *sōshi-kaimei*, effective in 1940, was nominally voluntary, but the Government-General enforced it through schools, employers, and local officials, and the great majority of Korean households registered Japanese-style names. The renaming of Sook-hee as Tamako condenses this history into a domestic act: the servant's name is replaced by one her mistress's household can pronounce. In post-liberation Korea the collaborator, *chinilpa*, became a principal figure of national opprobrium, and in 2005 the National Assembly enacted legislation to reclaim property acquired through collaboration. The film's disposal of Kouzuki's fortune is therefore pointed. It passes to a Korean thief and a Japanese orphan, who carry it out of both nations.

3.4 The contrapuntal country house

Said's reading of *Mansfield Park* (Said 1993) found the English country house sustained by colonial property that the novel scarcely names: Sir Thomas Bertram's Antiguan plantation. Park's transposition renders that dependency spatial and explicit. The country house is no longer sustained by a distant colony; it has been built inside one. The neo-Victorian becomes the neo-colonial, and what Waters's novel shares with its Victorian models—a domestic interior whose wealth comes from elsewhere—is turned inside out.

3.5 The refusal of national allegory

Fredric Jameson's claim that third-world texts necessarily project a political dimension in the form of national allegory (Jameson 1986) drew Aijaz Ahmad's rebuttal that the category homogenized heterogeneous literatures under a first-world gaze (Ahmad 1987). Korean nationalist discourse has often figured the colonized nation as a violated woman, most consequentially in the memory politics of Japanese military sexual slavery. From 1932 to 1945 the Imperial Japanese Army and Navy established and ran so-called comfort stations, in which women and girls, Korean women among the largest groups, were held and repeatedly raped by soldiers; many were procured through deception, coercion, abduction, or sale by brokers working for the military. Estimates of their number range from tens of thousands to about two hundred thousand. The contributors to *Dangerous Women*, among them Hyunah Yang and Chungmoo Choi, showed how such figuration can subordinate women's testimony to the nation's honor (Kim and Choi 1998; Yang 1998). Ueno Chizuko (1998) criticized the appropriation of survivors by nationalist frameworks on both sides of the strait.

The Handmaiden declines the allegory with unusual precision. The violated woman of its backstory is Japanese. Her abuser is her guardian, Kouzuki, a Korean performing Japaneseness, and the man who schemes to have her committed for her fortune, Fujiwara, is another. The alliance that liberates her crosses the colonial line, joining a Japanese heiress to a Korean thief against the men of both nations. The female body is de-allegorized: it ceases to be a figure for the nation and becomes, again, a body that belongs to its bearer.

3.6 The period's women: New Women, Seitō, Class S

The 1920s and 1930s were also the period of East Asian feminist modernity, and the film's women are historically plausible. In Korea the *sinyeoseong*, the New Women, advocated free love (*jayu yeonae*) and attacked the Confucian family. Na Hye-seok (1896–1948), Korea's first professional woman painter in oils,

published "A Confession of Divorce" in 1934, indicting the sexual double standard that had ruined her; she died destitute. Kim Il-yeop founded the journal *Sin yeoja* (New Woman) in 1920. In Japan the Seitō society (1911–16) opened its journal with Hiratsuka Raichō's manifesto proclaiming that woman had originally been the sun. Itō Noe, its later editor, was strangled in September 1923, together with her partner Ōsugi Sakae and his six-year-old nephew, by military police under the officer Amakasu Masahiko. The killings came in the weeks after the Great Kantō earthquake, when vigilante groups, police, and soldiers in and around Tokyo also killed several thousand Koreans on rumors that they were poisoning wells. Same-sex intimacy also belonged to Seitō's history, notably in Hiratsuka's attachment to Otake Kōkichi.

The schoolgirl culture of *esu* (S, for sister) romance, whose literature Yoshiya Nobuko shaped in *Hana monogatari* (Flower Tales, 1916–24), offered an idiom for intense female attachment that the period's discourse treated as a phase preceding marriage. Jennifer Robertson's "Dying to Tell" (1999) reads the love suicides of women in imperial Japan as attempts to speak a desire to which the social order allowed no future. The film's interrupted hanging must be read against this history. Its heroines refuse the *shinjū*, the double love-suicide hallowed in Japanese drama since Chikamatsu, as the only consummation available to unsanctioned love.

3.7 Kaneko Fumiko: the historical precedent

The most exact historical precedent for the film's central alliance is Kaneko Fumiko (1903–1926), a Japanese anarchist who joined her life and politics to the Korean anarchist Pak Yeol and identified herself with Koreans as fellow victims of the imperial order. Police took the two into custody days after the 1923 earthquake, in the roundups of Koreans and radicals that accompanied the massacre, and they were later convicted of high treason on a charge of plotting against the imperial family. Her death sentence was commuted to life imprisonment, and in July 1926 she was found hanged in her cell in Utsunomiya prison; the authorities recorded a suicide. Her memoir, written in prison, was published in 1931. Lee Joon-ik's film *Anarchist from Colony* (2017) brought her story to Korean audiences a year after *The Handmaiden*. Hideko's alliance with Sook-hee restages Kaneko's crossing of the colonial line. Where history ended in a prison noose, the film interrupts the noose and sails.

3.8 The decade of the counterfeit

The 1930s were a decade of insolvency in the guarantee. Britain left the gold standard in September 1931, Japan in December 1931 under Finance Minister

Takahashi Korekiyo, and the United States in 1933. In 1934 John Carter and Graham Pollard's *An Enquiry into the Nature of Certain Nineteenth Century Pamphlets* exposed Thomas J. Wise, the most eminent bibliophile in England, as the forger of dozens of supposed first editions, among them a privately printed "Reading, 1847" edition of Elizabeth Barrett Browning's *Sonnets from the Portuguese*. Kouzuki is Wise's colonial double, a collector-forger whose authority rests on his own counterfeits. André Gide's *The Counterfeiters* (1925), a novel of false coins and false selves, had already made the counterfeit the master trope of modernist fiction, and Goux (1984) read it as the literary register of the end of monetary convertibility. The decade in which *The Handmaiden* is set is the decade in which value openly lost its referent.



Part Two

Analytics

Part II examines eight operations through which the film thinks: the constitution of a patriarchal archive, the regimes of gaze and voice, the epistemology of touch, the reversal of the traffic in women, the dialectic of narration and recognition, the logic of copies without originals, the ethics of destroying an archive, and the topology of flight.



Chapter 4

The Library as Arkheion

Voice, Writing, and the Commodity That Speaks

4.1 Domiciliation and interdiction

Jacques Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) recalls that the Greek *arkheion* was the house of the archons, the magistrates who held and interpreted the official documents of the city. The archive is defined by domiciliation, the lodging of documents in a patriarchal residence, and by consignation, the gathering of signs into a single corpus under a single authority. Kouzuki's library is the arkheion in its purest domestic form. Its documents are lodged in the master's house; he alone interprets, prices, and grants access; and its corpus is unified by his taste and by his forgeries.

The library is also defined by interdiction: servants are forbidden to enter it. Virginia Woolf's *A Room of One's Own* (1929) records the analogous scene at the threshold of an Oxbridge library, where the narrator is turned back by a gentleman who informs her that women are admitted only in the company of a Fellow or with a letter of introduction. The English title of Park's film activates an older topos. Scholastic theology called philosophy its *ancilla*, its handmaid, a subordinate discipline admitted to the sanctuary only in service. The handmaiden of the title is the figure the library excludes. She will become the figure who empties it.

4.2 Pharmakon: the black tongue

Kouzuki's tongue is stained black with ink. The image condenses Derrida's reading of Plato's *Phaedrus* in "Plato's Pharmacy" (Derrida 1972). There writing is a *pharmakon*, both remedy and poison, which Western metaphysics subordinates to the living voice as the presence of meaning in speech. In Kouzuki's household the hierarchy is inverted. A living voice, Hideko's, is subordinated to dead letters, the books, and the master's own organ of speech has been colonized by the substance of writing. The black tongue is

logocentrism's nightmare, a mouth in which speech has become writing and writing has become poison. The poison reaches its literal form in the mercury of the final scene.

Umberto Eco's *The Name of the Rose* (1980) supplies the closest literary analogue. Its monastic library guards a forbidden book on laughter, the lost second book of Aristotle's *Poetics*. The book's pages are poisoned, so that readers who moisten their fingers to turn them die, and its guardian, the blind Jorge of Burgos, finally eats it as the library burns. Both libraries are fortresses of male custody over forbidden knowledge; both treat women and laughter as threats to the order of the book; both end in the destruction of the collection. The difference is that Eco's library is destroyed by its guardian to preserve a secret, and Kouzuki's by the women it held in order to release one.

Stéphane Mallarmé's late dictum that everything in the world exists in order to end in a book is Kouzuki's metaphysics. Jorge Luis Borges's "The Library of Babel" (1941) imagines the universe as a library; Kouzuki tries to make a library his universe. The women reverse the Mallarméan proposition. The books must end in the world—torn, in the water, unmade into matter.

4.3 The commodity that speaks

In the first chapter of *Capital* (1867), Marx imagines commodities able to speak and has them say that their use-value does not concern them; what belongs to them as things is only their exchange-value. Hideko is a commodity that literally speaks, and her speech is itself sold. Her recitations add value to the counterfeit books, so that performance functions as appraisal. Her voice is labor-power whose product, the auctioned price, belongs entirely to another. She is, in addition, the eventual object of the largest transaction in the film, the marriage through which her fortune passes to a husband.

Luce Irigaray's "Women on the Market" (1977) extends Marx to the exchange of women. Women circulate among men as commodities: the virgin as pure exchange-value, the mother as use-value, the prostitute as both. The social order is a *hom(m)o-sexual* economy, a commerce among men in which women serve as the medium of exchange. Her companion essay, "Commodities among Themselves," poses a counterfactual: what if the goods refused to go to market and conducted exchanges among themselves? *The Handmaiden* is the narrative realization of that hypothesis. The household contains three female commodities. The aunt, the first reader, died in circulation. Hideko and Sook-hee, the second and third, withdraw from the market and trade with each other—touch for touch, truth for truth, freedom for freedom.

4.4 The ventriloquized voice

Kaja Silverman's *The Acoustic Mirror* (1988) demonstrated that classical cinema binds the female voice to the synchronized body and the diegetic interior, reserving the disembodied authority of voice-over for men. *The Handmaiden* grants voice-over to both women, Sook-hee in Part One and Hideko in Part Two, while staging inside the library the male authorship of female speech. The film thus contains both regimes, the ventriloquized woman and the narrating woman, and it narrates the passage from one to the other.

Michel Chion (1982) identified the screaming point of classical cinema: the woman's scream as the vanishing point toward which narrative and spectacle converge, a voice beyond language that the film is built to elicit. Hideko's recitation is a disciplined anti-scream, affect perfectly modulated and made legible. Julia Kristeva's distinction between the semiotic, the rhythmic and pre-symbolic dimension of signification, and the symbolic, its grammatical and thetic order, clarifies what the library has done (Kristeva 1974). Hideko's voice has been purged of the semiotic and rendered entirely symbolic, a perfect instrument of the master's syntax. The bells of the final scene will be the semiotic's return.

4.5 Castration or decapitation

Hélène Cixous, in "Castration or Decapitation?" (1981), retells an anecdote from the life of Sun Tzu. Commanded to drill the king's concubines, the general finds that they laugh at his orders; he beheads the two who lead them, and the rest obey in silence. Cixous concludes that women are threatened not with castration but with decapitation: the loss of the head, of voice, of reason. The film's distribution of violence follows this division precisely. The men are threatened with castration—Fujiwara's fingers, his boast about his intact genitals, Kouzuki's impotence. The women are threatened with decapitation in its bloodless forms: the noose that killed the aunt, the noose Hideko fastens to the same tree, the asylum that removes the head by declaring it mad. The scene at the tree is the film's crisis because it is the moment at which the threat proper to women is about to be completed.

4.6 The illegible hanging

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) ends with the case of Bhuvaneswari Bhaduri, a young woman who hanged herself in North Calcutta in 1926. She waited until she was menstruating, so that her death could not be read as the consequence of an illicit pregnancy; she had in fact been unable to carry out a political assassination entrusted to her. Her message,

written with her body, went unread for a generation. Spivak's point is that the subaltern woman's speech fails not because she is silent but because no one is positioned to read her.

The aunt's hanging is such an illegible text. Kouzuki reads it as madness, which is to say that he does not read it. Hideko's attempted hanging repeats the text. Sook-hee arrives in time to stop it, and she reads it correctly, as an accusation of the order that produced it and of her own complicity in that order. The handmaiden is the first reader in the film who reads a woman's body for meaning rather than for price.

4.7 The mannequin

Martha Nussbaum's analysis of objectification (1995) identifies seven ways of treating a person as a thing: instrumentality, denial of autonomy, inertness, fungibility, violability, ownership, and denial of subjectivity. Rae Langton (2009) added reduction to body, reduction to appearance, and silencing. The wooden mannequin of the library's demonstrations is the library's ideal woman and satisfies every term: it is inert, fungible, violable, owned, and silent, a body without a subject. The training of Hideko aimed to produce a mannequin with a voice. It succeeded in everything except the voice, which turned out to belong to her.



Chapter 5

The Scopic and Its Discontents

Gaze, Masquerade, and the Frenzy of the Audible

5.1 The apparatus diegetized

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) argued that classical cinema is structured by a male gaze that splits pleasure into voyeurism, which investigates and punishes the woman, and fetishistic scopophilia, which freezes her into spectacle; the woman's function is her to-be-looked-at-ness. Kouzuki's reading room is Mulvey's apparatus built inside the fiction. A darkened audience of men sits immobile before a lit stage; a woman performs; a male host controls the narrative and its interruptions; and desire is organized by the distance between seats and stage. Jean-Louis Baudry (1970) compared the cinematic apparatus to Plato's cave, its prisoners immobilized before projected images, and Christian Metz (1977) identified the voyeur's need to keep his object at a distance. Both describe the gentlemen exactly: seated, still, audible only in their breathing, held at the edge of a spectacle they consume without touching.

By building the apparatus into the diegesis, the film indicts its own spectators. Like Hitchcock's *Rear Window* (1954) and Michael Powell's *Peeping Tom* (1960), it invites an identification with the watching men that it then renders shameful. The spectator who came for the sex scenes recognizes himself among the collectors.

5.2 The masquerade as weapon

Joan Riviere's "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929) described a woman who, having demonstrated intellectual mastery in public, compulsively performed flirtatious femininity to avert anticipated reprisal from the men she had outshone; Riviere concluded that womanliness and the masquerade are the same thing. Mary Ann Doane (1982) turned the concept to film theory, arguing that the masquerade creates a distance between the woman and her image that

allows a female spectator to read femininity as a mask rather than a destiny.

Hideko's performance before the collectors is a masquerade in Riviere's sense, a femininity worn to avert punishment. The film's twist reveals that the mask has become a weapon. The impassive, slightly abstracted face she perfected for the gentlemen is the face with which she deceives Sook-hee in Part One and the Count throughout. The library's training, intended to make her legible to men, has made her illegible to them.

5.3 The oppositional gaze and the lesbian look

In "The Oppositional Gaze" (1992), bell hooks argued that subordinated spectators, Black women above all, develop a critical look that refuses identification and interrogates what it sees. Sook-hee's gaze passes through three stages: the appraising look of a thief estimating the value of jewels and gowns, the look of desire, and the look of recognition. Its moral evolution is the moral evolution of the film. Part Two's replay discloses that the apparent object of Part One was looking back throughout; Hideko's gaze, unseen by Sook-hee and by the spectator, had been composing its own drama in parallel.

Teresa de Lauretis described cinema as a technology of gender (1987) and showed, in "Sexual Indifference and Lesbian Representation" (1988), how difficult it is to represent lesbian desire in a medium organized around sexual difference, where a look between women is readily absorbed into a male economy of spectacle. The film negotiates this difficulty by doubling its looks. Its decisive exchanges between the women are shown from each side, so that neither woman is only an image for the other.

5.4 The explicitness controversy

The film's sex scenes provoked its strongest critical dissent. Critics compared them to those of Kechiche's *Blue Is the Warmest Color* (2013), whose explicitness had been criticized by Julie Maroh, the author of its source graphic novel, as a heterosexual fantasy of lesbian sex. The charge against Park is that a male director's camera reinstates in the bedroom the regime it criticized in the library.

The charge deserves a serious answer, and five considerations bear on it. First, the film's diegetic thematization of voyeurism makes any recuperation self-indicting: a spectator who consumes the scenes as the collectors consume Hideko's readings has been shown what he is doing. Second, the screenplay is co-authored by a woman, Chung Seo-kyung. Third, the first lovemaking is shown twice, and the second showing changes its meaning, which is the opposite of pornography's compulsive repetition of the same. Fourth, the

women's pleasure is never watched within the diegesis, whereas Hideko's readings are always watched. Fifth, laughter, negotiation, and conversation punctuate the scenes, interrupting spectacle with speech. None of this abolishes the extra-diegetic camera, and the film knows it. Its reflexivity does not exonerate; it exposes. The debate is better posed against Céline Sciamma's *Portrait of a Lady on Fire* (2019), whose poetics of the female gaze elides sex in favor of equal looks. Park chooses depiction over ellipsis, and the choice remains contestable.

5.5 The three body genres

Linda Williams's "Film Bodies" (1991) grouped pornography, horror, and melodrama as body genres, each organized around a female body seized by an involuntary excess—orgasm, terror, tears—that the spectator's body mimics. *The Handmaiden* contains all three and redirects each. Melodrama's tears are given to mutual recognition rather than sacrifice. Horror's violence is turned against the male body, in the basement. Pornography's ecstasy is shifted into a sonic register.

5.6 The frenzy of the audible

In *Hard Core* (1989), Williams borrowed Jean-Louis Comolli's phrase "the frenzy of the visible" (Comolli 1980) to describe pornography's drive to make involuntary female pleasure visible. The drive is structurally frustrated, since female orgasm resists visual proof, and the genre compensates by displaying male ejaculation as substitute evidence. The ending of *The Handmaiden* answers this impasse. In their cabin on the ship to Shanghai, the women make love with silver bells, an erotic instrument whose use had been recited in the library for the profit of collectors. The bells ring.

I call this the **frenzy of the audible**. The proof of pleasure is converted from image to sound, from evidence for an observer into an event shared by those who produce it. No male body supplies the evidence, no witness is present, and the camera cannot see what makes the bells ring; it can only record that they ring. The library's economy rendered a woman's voice a commodity heard by men. The ship's economy renders the women's pleasure a sound heard by themselves.

5.7 Lacan's not-all and its answer

Jacques Lacan's Seminar XX, *Encore* (1972–73; Lacan 1975), posited a feminine jouissance that is not-all inscribed in the phallic function: a supplementary enjoyment that the woman experiences but about which, Lacan claimed, she can

say nothing. Bernini's *Ecstasy of Saint Teresa* was his emblem. Irigaray objected that this made male theorists the spokesmen of a pleasure they denied women the capacity to articulate (Irigaray 1977). The bells answer both positions. The women's pleasure is neither ineffable nor ventriloquized by a man; it is articulated in a language that is not speech, a sound they make together and that only they need to understand.



Chapter 6

Fingersmithing

Toward a Haptic Epistemology

6.1 The lost word

Waters's title disappears in Park's film, and its meaning is redistributed across the image track. The fingersmith survives as a field of hands. Hideko keeps a collection of gloves, which she wears constantly. Sook-hee's thief's fingers lift what they appraise. The Count, in the guise of a painting master, instructs the heiress at her easel. A metal thimble enters Hideko's mouth. Kouzuki's book-cutter severs Fujiwara's fingers. The women's ungloved hands, finally, find each other. The finger, more than the eye or the tongue, is the film's organ of knowledge. I call the theory of knowledge this implies a **dactylic epistemology**: knowing as touching, appropriating, and caring, opposed to the library's knowing as seeing, reading, and pricing.

6.2 Aristotle and the sense without distance

Aristotle's *De Anima* treats touch as the primary sense, the one without which no animal could exist, and notes its peculiarity: its medium is the flesh itself, so that touch abolishes the distance on which sight depends. The library is a regime of distance. Its knowledge is the voyeur's and the appraiser's, and its law forbids contact; even Hideko's hands are sheathed. The women's relation inaugurates a regime of proximity, in which knowledge is acquired, and truth verified, by contact.

6.3 The servant's hand and the lady's glove

Anne McClintock's *Imperial Leather* (1995) reconstructed the relationship between Arthur Munby, a Victorian gentleman who spent decades recording the hands and bodies of working women, and Hannah Cullwick, a maid-of-all-work whose secret union with him converted her labor into an erotic theater of servitude. Munby's fixation was the large, reddened,

roughened hand of the working woman, the visible mark of labor that the gentlewoman's glove existed to conceal. McClintock showed how domestic servitude, imperial racism, and fetishism converged on that hand, and how leather became the material sign of the boundary between classes and races.

The Handmaiden inverts Munby's fetish. Here it is the lady's gloved hand that is fetishized, enclosed, collected, and displayed by her guardian, and it is the maid's bare, skilled hand that becomes the agent of the lady's ungloving. The glove is the class boundary rendered as a second skin. Its removal is not the lady's descent into labor but the abolition of the boundary that made her hand a museum piece.

6.4 The skin-ego

Didier Anzieu's *Le Moi-peau* (1985) proposed that the ego is first constituted as a psychic envelope modeled on the skin, formed through the infant's experience of being held, washed, and touched. Hideko, deprived of maternal touch and delivered to the library as a child, wears her gloves as a prosthetic skin-ego, an envelope supplied from outside where none was formed from within. Sook-hee's labor as maid is literally the labor of the skin: she bathes, dresses, laces, unlaces, and files. In the scenes of service the film shows the reparative care that Anzieu describes as forming the envelope, performed by a woman who is not a mother and who is about to become a lover. The progression from service to care to eros is the formation of a skin.

6.5 The thimble

The film's first erotic event is an act of care. In the bath, Hideko sucks a candy and complains of a sharp tooth that cuts her cheek. Sook-hee slips a thimble onto her finger and files the tooth down inside Hideko's mouth. Everything in the scene is mediated touch—metal over flesh, a finger inside a mouth, an instrument of needlework turned to surgery—and everything in it is intimate. The tooth that wounds from within is removed by a touch that does not wound. The thimble, designed to protect the seamstress's finger, protects the lady's mouth. It is the hinge between the two mediated tactilities of the film's first half, glove and thimble, and the unmediated tactility of its second.

6.6 The chiasm of two

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's late ontology took as its paradigm one hand touching the other: the touching hand can become touched and the touched become touching, in a reversibility that never quite coincides (Merleau-Ponty 1964). Irigaray's critique in *An Ethics of Sexual Difference* (1984) held that this

reversibility remains the solipsism of one body, a sameness that cannot accommodate the other. Her own figure, from "When Our Lips Speak Together" (Irigaray 1977), is the two lips that touch each other continuously, an image of a pleasure that is plural from the start.

The women's mutual touch is a chiasm across difference. It joins two bodies separated by class, nation, and language, and subsumes neither in the other. Each touches and is touched; neither is only the hand that grasps or the hand that is grasped. Merleau-Ponty's reversibility is realized between persons rather than within one body, and Irigaray's plurality is realized as an encounter between two subjects rather than as an anatomical given.

6.7 The caress without mystery

Emmanuel Levinas's phenomenology of eros in *Totality and Infinity* (1961) describes the caress as a seeking of what is not yet, an approach to an alterity that withdraws, and identifies that alterity with the feminine as mystery. Simone de Beauvoir objected in the introduction to *The Second Sex* (1949) that this assigns woman the role of Other from a man's point of view. Irigaray's "The Fecundity of the Caress" (1984) reread Levinas to restore to the woman her own position as caressing subject. *The Handmaiden* removes the mystery from the caress without removing its alterity. Neither woman is the feminine for the other; each is caressing and caressed. The alterity the caress approaches is not a metaphysical femininity but the concrete other history—colonial, servile, criminal, aristocratic—of the beloved.

6.8 Sartre's hand

In *Being and Nothingness* (1943), Jean-Paul Sartre's best-known example of bad faith is a woman who, on a date, allows her companion to take her hand and leaves it inert in his, neither consenting nor withdrawing, so that it becomes a thing rather than an act. Hideko's conduct throughout the Count's courtship—gloved, passive compliance that neither invites nor refuses—reproduces Sartre's scene. But the film reveals that what appears to be bad faith is strategy. Hideko's inertness is a performance within a con of which she is co-author. The film criticizes Sartre's example from the position of its object: what reads to the philosopher as evasion may be the tactical self-objectification of someone who has no other room in which to act.

6.9 The severed fingers

In the basement, Kouzuki uses a bookbinder's cutting machine to sever Fujiwara's fingers, trimming a man as one trims the edges of a book. The

procedure applies the library's logic to its last subject: the man who forged a title is edited like a forged volume. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) lists severed limbs among the images of uncanny dread and links them to the castration complex, and the finger is the phallus's classic substitute. Fujiwara's boast that he dies with his genitals intact is therefore a misreading of his own fate. He has already been castrated where it mattered, in the hands with which he painted, swindled, and seduced.

Jane Campion's *The Piano* (1993) provides the counter-image. Stewart severs one of Ada's fingers with an axe, mutilating the hand through which a mute woman speaks. Vivian Sobchack's essay on that film, "What My Fingers Knew" (2004), describes how the spectator's own fingers grasp a film's tactile images before conscious understanding, making the viewer a cinesthetic subject. Laura Marks's account of haptic visuality (2000) names images that invite the eye to touch textures. *The Handmaiden* is saturated with such textures—silk, paper, water, lacquer, skin—and it reverses Campion's mutilation. In *The Piano*, patriarchy maims the woman's expressive hand. In *The Handmaiden*, the patriarchs maim each other's hands, and the women's hands go free.

6.10 Proposition

The film's dactylic epistemology can be stated as a proposition. To know a person in the library's regime is to see, read, and price her. To know a person in the women's regime is first to have one's hand in her pocket, then on her skin, then in her hand. Knowledge begins in theft, passes through care, and completes itself in reciprocity. Each stage is tactile, and each transforms the one before it.



Chapter 7

The Traffic Reversed

Triangles, Fungibility, and the Counterplot

7.1 The exchange of women as con

Claude Lévi-Strauss's *The Elementary Structures of Kinship* (1949) made the exchange of women among men the foundation of kinship and therefore of culture. Gayle Rubin's "The Traffic in Women" (1975) turned the analysis into critique: the exchange of women is the political economy of sex, the institution through which women become conduits of relations among men and through which the sex/gender system reproduces female subordination. *The Handmaiden* renders the traffic in women as fraud. Kouzuki intends to marry his ward to secure the fortune that passes through her; Fujiwara intends to marry her and commit her to secure it first. Each man's plot routes property through a woman's body. The con does not distort the traffic in women. It reveals the traffic's ordinary structure by accelerating it.

7.2 Between men

Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's *Between Men* (1985) showed that the canonical erotic triangle of the European novel, two men competing for a woman, is fundamentally a bond between the men, a homosocial desire for which the woman is pretext and medium. The film multiplies such triangles. Fujiwara and Kouzuki compete for Hideko; Fujiwara employs Sook-hee as an instrument of his pursuit; the collectors form a homosocial society whose common object is a woman's recited voice. Ueno Chizuko's *Onna-girai* (*Misogyny*, 2010) applied Sedgwick's model to Japanese society, defining homosociality as the mutual recognition of men constituted through the exclusion of women. The reading club is an institution of exactly this kind.

The basement finale distills the homosocial bond. Kouzuki's last demand of his rival is not money or revenge but narrative: he wants to be told what happened on the wedding night. The two men's final intimacy is an erotic

storytelling session conducted in a torture chamber, and its consummation is a shared death by poison. The triangle has collapsed into its truth, a male dyad sealed in a cellar.

7.3 The counterplot

Terry Castle's "Sylvia Townsend Warner and the Counterplot of Lesbian Fiction" (1993) proposed that lesbian narrative works by reconfiguring Sedgwick's triangle. The canonical male–female–male triangle becomes female–male–female, and the male term, once a mediator, is expelled, leaving the two women joined. *The Handmaiden* executes Castle's counterplot with diagrammatic precision. Fujiwara begins as the mediator through whom each woman relates to the other: he introduces Sook-hee into the house, and he is the object Hideko pretends to desire. In the second movement he is used by both women as an instrument. In the third he is evicted—drugged, abandoned, and finally destroyed in the sealed male space of the basement. The women are left joined, the mediator subtracted.

7.4 Fungibility and its reversal

Nussbaum's term fungibility names the treatment of a person as interchangeable with others of the same type, and fungibility is the motor of the con. Sook-hee is chosen because she can be substituted for Hideko, a woman administratively exchangeable for another woman, as Anne Catherick was for Laura Fairlie and Judy for Madeleine. The asylum ratifies the exchange by registering her under the Countess's name.

The film's moral reversal is to convert substitutability into irreplaceability. Love, in its account, is the recognition of the non-fungible. Montaigne explained his friendship with La Boétie by saying only that it was because it was he and because it was I. That formula, which cites no reason other than the persons themselves, is the precise antithesis of fungibility. The con chose Sook-hee because any maid would do. The love that undoes the con exists because only this one would.

7.5 The infant trade and reproductive futurism

The den's commerce in infants extends the traffic in women to its products. Silvia Federici (2004) traced capitalism's primitive accumulation through the expropriation of women's reproductive bodies, and Maria Mies (1986) argued that colonization and housewifization were twin processes, extracting value from colonized lands and from women's unwaged labor. The den is the intersection of both. Its women perform the reproductive labor of feeding and

tending infants, labor that is then realized as commodities exported across the colonial border.

Lee Edelman's *No Future* (2004) identified reproductive futurism, the political order's investment in the figure of the Child, as the horizon that queerness refuses. The den literalizes the Child as merchandise. The women's ending refuses reproduction without refusing the future: it is futurity without a child, closer to José Esteban Muñoz's queer horizon (2009) than to Edelman's negativity. In the year of the film's release, Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) issued the slogan "Make kin not babies," proposing kinship as an elective practice across boundaries rather than genealogical reproduction. The film's final household is kin without babies.

7.6 The Bertha plan abandoned

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) read Bertha Mason, the Creole wife confined in the attic of *Jane Eyre* (1847), as the heroine's dark double, the embodiment of a rage the heroine cannot express. Spivak's "Three Women's Texts and a Critique of Imperialism" (1985) turned this reading against itself. The feminist individualism of *Jane Eyre*, she argued, is purchased by the sacrifice of Bertha, the colonial woman consigned to madness and finally to self-immolation so that the English heroine can marry. The emancipation of the metropolitan woman is built on the madness and death of the colonial woman. Jean Rhys's *Wide Sargasso Sea* (1966) gave Bertha her history and her voice.

Hideko's original plan is exactly the *Jane Eyre* structure. A Japanese heiress, the metropolitan woman of this colonial order, will win her freedom by having a colonized servant certified as mad and confined in her place, under her name. Sook-hee is designed to be Bertha. Part Two is the drama of Hideko's renunciation of this design, which I call the **Bertha plan**: the moment at which the metropolitan woman refuses to purchase her emancipation with the colonized woman's madness. *The Handmaiden* thus answers Spivak's critique from within its plot. Rhys gave Bertha a voice. Park gives Bertha the heiress's love and the escape the heiress had meant to keep for herself, and he makes the abandonment of the Bertha plan the condition of the heiress's own freedom.

7.7 From commodity exchange to gift

Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) described exchange systems in which gifts create bonds, obligations, and rank. As the women withdraw from the market, their relation takes the form of a gift economy: each gives the other her freedom, and the betrayals each has committed are cancelled by forgiveness rather than

repaid. The gift economy in its most extreme form, the destruction of wealth in the potlatch, returns in Chapter 10, when the library is destroyed.



Chapter 8

The Dialectic of the Double-Cross

Narration, Recognition, Acknowledgment

8.1 Three parts, three moments

The film's tripartite structure is dialectical. Part One presents a consciousness certain of itself: Sook-hee believes she knows the plot, and the spectator, sharing her focalization, believes the same. Part Two negates that certainty. Hideko's perspective reveals Sook-hee's knowledge to have been the object of another plot, so that the first consciousness is shown to have been the instrument of the second. Part Three is neither the first perspective nor the second but their sublation into a joint subject, a plot authored by both women together. The movement is Hegelian, and its terminus is the formula Hegel gives in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) for the first appearance of spirit: an I that is a We, and a We that is an I.

8.2 Mistress and maid

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage describes two self-consciousnesses that confront each other in a struggle for recognition to the death. The victor becomes master and the vanquished slave. But the master depends on the slave's recognition, which is worthless because it is coerced, while the slave, through fear and formative labor, achieves a self-consciousness the master cannot attain. Alexandre Kojève's lectures (1947) made this the motor of history.

The relation between Hideko and Sook-hee begins as lordship and bondage in its most literal social form, mistress and maid, and it reproduces the dialectic's ironies. The mistress depends on the maid for every bodily need, and the maid's labor gives her a knowledge of the mistress's body that the mistress lacks. The film transforms the dialectic at its crisis. The struggle to the death is replaced by the scene at the tree, in which one consciousness's death is prevented by the other. Recognition is achieved not through risking the other's

life but through rescuing it. The film rewrites the founding scene of Hegelian intersubjectivity as an act of care.

8.3 Bonds of love and spheres of recognition

Jessica Benjamin's *The Bonds of Love* (1988) reinterpreted Hegel through feminist psychoanalysis. Domination arises when the tension between self-assertion and recognition of the other collapses, so that one party asserts without recognizing and the other recognizes without asserting. The film's three dyads chart Benjamin's spectrum. Kouzuki and Hideko form a relation of pure domination. Hideko and Fujiwara form an instrumental alliance in which each uses the other while withholding recognition. Hideko and Sook-hee achieve a relation in which each asserts herself and recognizes the other.

Axel Honneth's *The Struggle for Recognition* (1992) distinguished three spheres of recognition—love, rights, and solidarity—and made love the first, the sphere in which a person acquires the basic self-confidence on which the others rest. Kouzuki's exploitation of Hideko, begun when she was a child, destroyed that self-confidence by treating her body and voice as his property. The women's love restores it, and does so in the absence of the other two spheres. Neither woman has rights in the colonial order, and their solidarity is a society of two.

8.4 Refocalization and the paralipsis

Gérard Genette's narratology (1972) distinguishes internal focalization, in which narration is restricted to what a character knows, from paralipsis, the withholding of information that the chosen focalization would include. Part One is restricted to Sook-hee's knowledge, and its concealment of Hideko's intentions is legitimate because Sook-hee does not know them. The twist is achieved not by deception but by refocalization: the same events, seen from Hideko's position, acquire a different meaning. The film's central repeated scene, the night on which Hideko asks to be taught what a husband will do, appears in both parts. Its images are largely the same; its meaning is transformed.

Akutagawa Ryūnosuke's "In a Grove" (1922), the source of Kurosawa's *Rashomon* (1950), presents incompatible testimonies about a rape and a killing, and the woman's account is contradicted by those of both men involved. Its lesson is the relativity of testimony. Park's two female accounts are not incompatible. The second does not refute the first; it receives it. Truth in this film is not relativized by multiple perspectives but completed by them, and the completion requires that each woman see what the other saw.

8.5 The purloined letter

In his "Seminar on 'The Purloined Letter'" (Lacan 1966), Lacan described three glances organizing Poe's tale: one that sees nothing, the King's or the police's; one that sees that the first sees nothing and believes its secret safe, the Queen's or the Minister's; and one that sees what has been left in the open, Dupin's. Part One distributes these positions. Sook-hee occupies the first, seeing nothing of the plot she serves. Fujiwara believes he occupies the third but occupies the second. Hideko occupies the third. In Part Two the distribution shifts, and in Part Three the women become a double Dupin, seeing what both men have left in the open: the Count's greed and the uncle's lust.

Derrida's reply to Lacan, "Le facteur de la vérité" (1975), insisted that a letter can always fail to arrive and that dissemination exceeds destination. The film's letters, plots, and messages arrive at unintended addresses. The women exploit this errancy, redirecting the men's plots to destinations the men did not design.

8.6 Skepticism and acknowledgment

Stanley Cavell's *The Claim of Reason* (1979) treats skepticism about other minds as a standing human possibility: I cannot know what another person thinks or feels with the certainty I seek. His response is a reorientation rather than a refutation. What the other requires of me is not knowledge but acknowledgment. The double-cross is lived skepticism. Each woman cannot know the other's mind, and each is in fact deceiving the other. The confession at the tree resolves the skepticism not by supplying knowledge, since neither can verify the other's sincerity, but by acknowledgment: each declares herself to the other and accepts the other's declaration.

Cavell's two genres sharpen the point. In the comedies of remarriage (1981), a couple educate each other through conversation into a renewed marriage. In the melodramas of the unknown woman (1996), a woman refuses marriage and achieves self-knowledge alone. Parts One and Two are a melodrama of the unknown woman, with *Gaslight* as their ancestor. Part Three is a comedy, but not of remarriage. I call it a **comedy of unmarriage**: a couple formed through conversation and mutual education against the institution of marriage, by two women who are at the end legally nothing to each other and wholly bound.

8.7 From paranoid to reparative spectatorship

Paul Ricoeur (1965) grouped Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud as masters of a hermeneutics of suspicion. Sedgwick's "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading" (2003) described paranoid reading as anticipatory and exposing,

determined above all not to be surprised, and reparative reading as assembling and risking hope. The film trains paranoia and then disarms it. Part One is a lesson in being deceived; Part Two rewards the spectator who has learned to suspect; Part Three withholds the final twist that a trained paranoia expects. Its last surprise is that there is none: the love is not a con. The spectator schooled in suspicion must learn to believe.

Mulvey's *Death 24x a Second* (2006) distinguished the possessive spectator, who seeks to master the image by pausing and repeating it, from the pensive spectator, who contemplates it. *The Handmaiden* builds the rewind into its structure. By replaying its own scenes, it converts the possessive desire to master the plot into a pensive attention to what the first viewing failed to see.

8.8 The child at the well

Mencius argued that human nature is good by appeal to a single scene. Anyone who suddenly sees a child about to fall into a well feels alarm and compassion—not to win favor with the parents, nor to earn the praise of neighbors, but spontaneously. That feeling is the sprout of *ren*, humaneness (*Mencius* 2A6). Sook-hee's rescue of Hideko at the tree is a Mencian event. Every calculation available to her—the con, the fee, her own safety—argues against intervention, and a spontaneous compassion overrides them all. The film locates the beginning of moral life inside a structure of calculation, at the moment calculation fails.

Korean Neo-Confucianism elaborated this scene in the Four–Seven Debate. Yi Hwang (Toegye) and Gi Daeseung (Gobong) corresponded from 1559 to 1566, and Yi I (Yulgok) later extended the dispute, over the relation between the Four Beginnings, the Mencian moral sprouts, and the Seven Emotions of the *Book of Rites*, among them love and desire. Toegye held that the Four issue from principle (*li*) and the Seven from material force (*gi*), a dualism that protected moral feeling from contamination by appetite. Gobong and, later, Yulgok insisted that the Four are a subset of the Seven, the good portion of ordinary emotion. *The Handmaiden* sides with Gobong and Yulgok and radicalizes their position. Compassion is not merely compatible with erotic love; it arises from within it. The sprout of humaneness grows in the soil of desire.

8.9 Forgiveness and promise

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) identifies two faculties that rescue action from its own predicaments. Forgiveness answers irreversibility, the fact that what has been done cannot be undone. Promising answers unpredictability, the fact that the consequences of action cannot be foreseen.

The double-cross generates both predicaments: each woman has betrayed the other irreversibly, and their future is radically uncertain. Forgiveness releases each from what she has done, and the joint plan binds both to what they will do. The relation that results is political in Arendt's sense, a small polity constituted by mutual promise, and it is the first polity in the film that is not founded on domination.



Chapter 9

Copies Without Originals

Rehearsal, Counterfeit Consummation, and Minor Language

9.1 The rehearsal that replaces the act

On the night at the center of the film, Hideko asks Sook-hee to teach her what a husband will do, and Sook-hee, playing the bridegroom, shows her. The scene is framed as rehearsal: a copy of a heterosexual consummation that has not yet taken place. That consummation never takes place. Hideko's wedding night with Fujiwara is unconsummated, and the blood that stains the sheet is counterfeit. The original that the rehearsal was supposed to imitate does not exist. The copy is the only consummation in the film.

Judith Butler argued in *Gender Trouble* (1990) and "Imitation and Gender Insubordination" (1991) that heterosexuality presents itself as the original of which homosexual relations are imitations, but that it is itself an imitation, a repeated performance that produces the effect of an original it never possessed. Gender is a copy without an original. *The Handmaiden* literalizes this argument as plot. The lesbian "copy" precedes and replaces the heterosexual "original," which survives only as a forgery staged for an audience.

9.2 Precession and aura

Jean Baudrillard's *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) described the precession of simulacra, the condition in which the map precedes and engenders the territory. The rehearsal precedes the act and replaces it. Walter Benjamin's essay on the work of art in the age of its technological reproducibility (1935–36) defined aura as a work's unique presence in time and space, which mechanical reproduction withers. Kouzuki manufactures aura: his forgeries counterfeit the rarity and provenance that make a book an object of desire. The only aura in the film, the unrepeatable presence of two persons to each other, is achieved in a scene that was designed to be a copy.

9.3 Autographic and allographic

Nelson Goodman's *Languages of Art* (1968) distinguished autographic arts, in which the history of production matters and forgery is therefore possible, from allographic arts, in which any correct instance is the work. A painting can be forged; a poem cannot, because any correct spelling of its text is the poem. Kouzuki's forgery is therefore of a particular kind. He does not forge texts; he forges editions, the autographic bodies of books—their paper, binding, and provenance. The texts his counterfeits contain remain, in Goodman's sense, genuine.

The distinction clarifies what the women destroy and what they keep. They destroy the autographic counterfeit, the proprietary edition that made erotic knowledge an object of collection and a source of rank. They keep the allographic knowledge, which survives the destruction of its bodies and passes into their practice. The bells are the proof. Erotic knowledge is liberated from its patriarchal edition.

9.4 Mise en abyme and the counterfeiters

André Gide coined the term *mise en abyme* in his journal in 1893, borrowing it from heraldry to name a work that contains a reduced image of itself. His novel *The Counterfeiters* (1925) contains a novelist writing a novel called *The Counterfeiters* while schoolboys circulate false coins. The reading sessions are the film's *mise en abyme*: a performance of erotic narrative before a paying audience, contained within a film that performs erotic narrative before a paying audience. The figure turns the film's critique of the library upon the film itself. Thomas J. Wise, the forger exposed in 1934, is the historical warrant that the decade understood its bibliophilia as an economy of counterfeits.

9.5 Maids at play

Jean Genet's *The Maids* (1947) stages two sisters, Claire and Solange, who in their mistress's absence perform a ritual in which one plays Madame and the other plays the maid, rehearsing a murder they can never carry out. The rehearsal ends with Claire drinking the poisoned tea meant for Madame. In Genet's theater, servants can only play at power, and the play can only kill a servant. Claude Chabrol's *La Cérémonie* (1995), adapted from Ruth Rendell's *A Judgement in Stone* (1977), joins an illiterate housemaid and a postmistress in the massacre of a bourgeois family: class revenge through female alliance.

The Handmaiden transforms both models. Its role-play is between mistress and maid rather than between two servants, and it changes the world rather than enclosing the players in ritual. Its violence is displaced from the employers

onto the men who traffic in women. The women commit no murder; the men kill each other.

9.6 Drag and escape

Hideko flees in masculine disguise. The disguise is not an aspiration to manhood but a means of passage through a world that does not let two women travel unaccompanied. Monique Wittig's "One Is Not Born a Woman" (1981; Wittig 1992) argued that woman is a class constituted by heterosexual relations of appropriation, and that lesbians, refusing those relations, are escapees from the class, comparable to runaway slaves. Hideko's suit is the costume of such an escape. It marks her exit not from her body but from the category the marriage contract assigned to it.

9.7 Unnaming

Ursula K. Le Guin's "She Unnames Them" (1985) imagines Eve returning to the animals the names Adam gave them, then returning her own name and walking away. The film's women shed the names imposed on them: Tamako, the Countess Fujiwara, the Lady. The renaming of Sook-hee belonged to a colonial politics of names; its undoing is a politics of unnaming. The opening of the *Daodejing* holds that the name that can be named is not the constant name. The film is not interested in a true name to be recovered. It is interested in freedom from names conferred by others.

9.8 Minor Japanese

Deleuze and Guattari's *Kafka: Toward a Minor Literature* (1975) defined a minor literature as one that a minority constructs within a major language, deterritorializing it so that everything in it becomes political and collective. Kafka, a Prague Jew writing in German, was their paradigm. *The Handmaiden* is minor cinema in this sense. Its Japanese is spoken largely by Korean actors, and Japanese viewers have remarked on the accents. The imperial language is uttered at one remove from itself, deterritorialized in the mouths of the colonized. Diegetically this is plausible for Kouzuki, Fujiwara, and Sook-hee, Korean characters who learned Japanese; extra-diegetically it extends to the Japanese heroine, played by a Korean actress. The film's Japanese is itself a counterfeit, and the film does not hide it.

The code-switching follows lines of power. Japanese is the language of the house, the library, and the mistress; Korean is the language of the servants, the den, and increasingly of intimacy. Several releases distinguished the two languages typographically in their subtitles, making the switches visible to

viewers who hear neither. Bakhtin's heteroglossia, the coexistence of socially stratified languages within one discourse, describes the soundtrack exactly (Bakhtin 1981). The women's intimacy is conducted in a creolized idiom of two.

9.9 Two titles

The Korean title, *Agassi*, names the young lady, and the Japanese release title, *Ojōsan*, does the same. The English title names the servant. In contemporary colloquial Korean, *agassi* can also designate a hostess in the entertainment trade, so that one word holds both the noble maiden and the commodified woman—the two positions the library assigned to Hideko at once. No single title is adequate to the film. Its true title is the pair, as its true subject is the couple.



Chapter 10

Iconoclasm Without Censorship

The Destruction of the Library and the Sex Wars

10.1 The scene

Before their flight, Hideko leads Sook-hee into the library and shows her what it contains and what it has been for. Sook-hee, seeing the images and understanding at last what her mistress has been made to perform, begins to destroy the books, and Hideko joins her. They tear pages, slash bindings, and throw volumes into water. The tone is jubilant, close to slapstick, and cathartic. The scene is the film's revolutionary act, and it is philosophically the most difficult, because the destruction of books carries the stigma of censorship.

10.2 Two burnings

The stigma has a precise historical shape in the film's decade. On 6 May 1933, students and SA men sacked Magnus Hirschfeld's Institute for Sexual Science in Berlin, and four days later its books were burned with other proscribed works in the Opernplatz. The Nazis destroyed the century's most important archive of sexual knowledge, one that served the persecuted and documented sexual and gender variance. Ray Bradbury's *Fahrenheit 451* (1953) later gave the image its canonical fictional form.

The women's destruction of Kouzuki's library is the formal inverse of the Berlin burning. The Nazis destroyed an emancipatory archive in the name of a purified nation and a compulsory sexuality. The women destroy a proprietary archive that served a collaborator's commerce and a male elite's pleasure, and they do so in the name of their own pleasure. The ethics of archive destruction cannot be decided by the act alone. It depends on whom the archive served, who owned it, and what knowledge survives its destruction.

10.3 Neither abolition nor libertinism

The feminist sex wars of the 1980s posed the question the scene answers. Andrea Dworkin's *Pornography: Men Possessing Women* (1981) and Catharine MacKinnon's legal theory (1987) treated pornography as a practice of subordination rather than a form of speech, and their 1983 civil-rights ordinance in Minneapolis sought to make it actionable. Gayle Rubin's "Thinking Sex" (1984) and the volume *Pleasure and Danger* edited by Carole Vance (1984), which grew from the 1982 Barnard conference, defended sexual minorities and sexual expression against what they regarded as a new moral panic.

The Handmaiden occupies neither position. It destroys a pornographic archive, which aligns it with abolition, and it depicts explicit lesbian sex with evident joy, which aligns it with the sex radicals. Its target is neither sexual representation as such nor its regulation but the ownership of the means of erotic production. The library's crime is not that it contains sexually explicit material, much of it violent. It is that it makes erotic knowledge private property, a source of rank and money for men, extracted from the voice of a girl held captive and made to recite it from childhood. The women do not abolish erotic knowledge; they expropriate it. They destroy the proprietary archive and keep the instrument, so that the bells pass from the collection to the cabin, from exchange-value to use-value. In this precise sense the film enacts Carter's moral pornography (1978): erotic representation turned to the critique of relations between the sexes.

10.4 Expenditure

Georges Bataille's "The Notion of Expenditure" (1933) and *The Accursed Share* (1949) defined sovereignty as the unproductive consumption of wealth, expenditure without return, against the bourgeois logic of accumulation. His model was the potlatch described by Mauss, in which chiefs destroy property to establish rank. The library's destruction is sovereign expenditure, the annihilation of accumulated value for no return. But it inverts the potlatch in one respect. Potlatch destroys wealth before witnesses to acquire prestige. The women destroy wealth without witnesses and against prestige, in order to dissolve the order of rank the library sustained. It is a potlatch against prestige.

10.5 Civilization and barbarism

In his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), Walter Benjamin held that every document of civilization is simultaneously a document of barbarism. Kouzuki's library is the perfect instance: refinement and cruelty are a single substance, bound in lacquer and paper. Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) identifies

within the archive a destructive drive, which he associates with Freud's death drive; the archive is haunted by the compulsion to destroy itself. The women's act is not that drive but its reversal. They destroy the archive in order to live, not in obedience to a compulsion toward death. What the library had stored was the death of the aunt and the slow death of the niece.

10.6 Carnival

Věra Chytilová's *Daisies* (1966) follows two young women through a series of anarchic provocations that culminates in the destruction of a lavish banquet. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) theorized carnival as the temporary suspension of hierarchy in laughter, feasting, and the grotesque body. Marleen Gorris's *A Question of Silence* (1982) ends with women laughing in a courtroom, a laughter that renders the law's proceedings absurd. The library's destruction belongs to this lineage of feminist carnival. It differs in being a carnival of two, without spectators, in a space built for spectators.

10.7 Refunctioning and poaching

Benjamin's "The Author as Producer" (1934) argued that progressive art must transform the apparatus of production rather than supply it with revolutionary content, borrowing from Brecht the term *Umfunktionierung*, refunctioning. The women refunction every apparatus they touch: the con plot, the Count's title, the asylum, the inn, the fortune, the bells. Michel de Certeau's *The Practice of Everyday Life* (1980) described reading as poaching, the reader's nomadic appropriation of a text owned by others, and distinguished the strategies of the powerful, who own places, from the tactics of the weak, who work in the spaces of others. One such tactic he called *la perruque*, the worker's diversion of the employer's time and materials to her own ends. Hideko's reading becomes poaching. She uses the library's knowledge to deceive, to plan, and finally to love. The library's corpus survives in her practice, stripped of its owner.



Chapter 11

Topologies of Flight

Cellar, Asylum, Sea

11.1 The vertical house

Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) described the house as a vertical being. The attic is the region of rational clarity; the cellar is the dark, subterranean region of irrational forces, where the house's unconscious lives. Kouzuki's estate has two axes. Its horizontal axis, the junction of the English and Japanese wings, is colonial. Its vertical axis, from the library to the basement, is libidinal. The library above recites what the basement below performs or threatens: the octopus in its tank, the instruments, the cutting machine, the punishments. The basement is the truth of the library, the place where the recited is enacted.

11.2 Bluebeard's chamber

Charles Perrault's "Bluebeard" (1697) supplied the Gothic tradition with the forbidden chamber in which a husband keeps the bodies of his previous wives, and with the key that, once stained with blood, cannot be cleaned. The aunt is Bluebeard's previous wife; the basement is the bloody chamber; the library's interdiction on servants is the forbidden door. Carter's rewriting in "The Bloody Chamber" (1979) made the bride a reader whose initiation into the Marquis's library precedes her discovery of his chamber. Park retains Carter's sequence and alters her rescue.

11.3 Confinement: the home cage and the asylum

Japan's Mental Patients' Custody Act of 1900 made families legally responsible for confining the mentally ill and authorized confinement at home, often in a wooden cage, the *zashikirō*. In 1918 the psychiatrist Kure Shūzō and his

colleague Kashida Gorō published a survey of such domestic confinement that became a landmark indictment of the system. Kouzuki's basement is a private *zashikirō*, the home cage turned to the discipline of a ward who is not mad but must be made to fear madness.

The asylum into which Sook-hee is committed belongs to the institutional history that Foucault's *History of Madness* (1961) traced to the great confinement of the seventeenth century, and that Phyllis Chesler's *Women and Madness* (1972) and Showalter's *The Female Malady* (1985) gendered. Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wall-Paper" (1892), in which a physician-husband's rest cure drives his wife into the madness it claimed to treat, is the period's sharpest literary image of medicine as marital power. The film's asylum is the instrument through which a husband disposes of a wife. It is also the place where the plot's substitution is legally ratified: Sook-hee becomes, on paper, the woman she was hired to replace.

11.4 The ship as heterotopia

In his 1967 lecture "Of Other Spaces" (Foucault 1984), Foucault defined heterotopias as real places that contest and invert the other spaces of a culture: cemeteries, prisons, asylums, gardens, colonies, brothels. He ended with the ship, a floating piece of space without a place, closed in on itself and given over to the infinite sea, and called it the heterotopia par excellence; civilizations without ships, he observed, lose their dreams. The film's final space is such a ship. The asylum is a heterotopia of deviation, a place for those who depart from the norm. The ship is a heterotopia of passage, belonging to no nation while it sails. In the asylum the women were separated; on the ship they are joined.

11.5 Smooth and striated

In *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980), Deleuze and Guattari distinguished striated space—gridded, measured, divided by fixed paths and enclosures—from smooth space, open and traversed by intensities and vectors. The sea is their archetype of smooth space, later striated by navigation and empire. The estate is striated: wings, thresholds, the library's interdiction, the stair to the basement, the line between the mistress's rooms and the servants'. The women's escape is a line of flight from striated to smooth space, and the film's last images, the sea and the enclosed cabin, are open and intimate at once.

11.6 Shanghai

Shanghai in the 1930s was a semi-colonial treaty port divided among the International Settlement, the French Concession, and the Chinese city, a refuge for exiles, revolutionaries, refugees, and impostors. From 1919 until 1932 it was the seat of the Provisional Government of the Republic of Korea. It was neither Japan nor Korea, and it was the place in East Asia where national belonging was most negotiable. The destination is chosen with precision: the women leave the jurisdiction of the empire and of the colony alike.

Woolf's *Three Guineas* (1938) declares that a woman has no country, wants none, and claims the whole world as her country. Hannah Arendt's *The Origins of Totalitarianism* (1951) identified in the stateless refugee the loss of the right to have rights, the condition of persons excluded from any political community. The women's flight makes them stateless in Arendt's sense, exposed and without protection. But it also constitutes a minimal political community, a plurality of two, in which each appears to the other as a person. The ship is Woolf's whole world reduced to a cabin.

11.7 Boats in the archive of feminist cinema

Jacques Rivette's *Céline and Julie Go Boating* (1974) follows two women who enter a house in which a patriarchal melodrama repeats endlessly, rescue the child it is about to destroy, and end on the water. *Marnie*'s honeymoon ship was the scene of a marital rape and an attempted suicide. Herman Melville's *The Confidence-Man* (1857) sets its procession of swindles aboard a Mississippi steamboat named the *Fidèle*, on April Fools' Day. The ship to Shanghai rewrites all three. It is the house of *Céline and Julie* left behind, the honeymoon ship without the husband, and a *Fidèle* without confidence men, on which the confidence game has been converted into confidence.

11.8 Horizon

José Esteban Muñoz's *Cruising Utopia* (2009) described queerness as a horizon, a not-yet-here that structures the present as anticipation. The film ends in transit, on a ship that has not arrived. Shanghai is not a utopia achieved but a destination that organizes desire. The final image is not a home but a passage, and its happiness is that of an open future rather than a settled one.



Part Three

Synthesis

The Second Forgery

Part III draws the genealogies and analyses together into a theory. Its four chapters define kleptopoiesis, fiduciary eros, the counterfeit commons, and post-genealogical humanism, and then test them against the strongest objections.



Chapter 12

Kleptopoiesis

A Theory of Larcenous Emancipation

12.1 Definition

I propose the term **kleptopoiesis**, from the Greek *kleptein*, to steal, and *poiēsis*, making, for the production of a form of life through the theft and refunctioning of the apparatuses that produced one's subjection. The concept is defined by four contrasts. It is not revolution, which seizes the apparatus of the state; the women seize nothing so large and found no state. It is not exodus, which departs without appropriating; the women leave, but they leave with the fortune, the bells, and the plot. It is not reform, which seeks inclusion in an existing apparatus on improved terms. And it is not mere crime, which appropriates within the logic of the market it robs; the women's theft dissolves the market relation rather than reproducing it. Kleptopoiesis takes the instruments of domination and makes them do what their designers never intended.

The film's catalogue of thefts is complete. The women steal the men's plot and redirect it. They steal the Count's marriage and empty it. They steal the asylum's procedure and reverse its object. They steal the library's erotic knowledge and transfer it from collection to practice. They steal the fortune and carry it out of two nations. The pickpocket's craft, with which the film begins, becomes its ethics.

12.2 *Voler*: to steal and to fly

Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) exploited the double sense of the French verb *voler*, to fly and to steal. Woman's gesture, she argued, is to fly in language and to make language fly, and women take after both birds and thieves: they steal into the language that excluded them and take flight from its

order. The film literalizes Cixous's pun. Sook-hee is a thief by trade, and both women, at the end, fly. Theft and flight are a single act. Cixous made theft the female relation to language; the film extends it to the entire symbolic economy of names, contracts, property, and images.

12.3 Prometheus and Pandora reversed

Western humanism has a founding theft. In Hesiod's *Theogony* and *Works and Days*, Prometheus steals fire for mortals, and Zeus retaliates by having the first woman fashioned and sent among men as a beautiful evil: Pandora, the gift that punishes the theft. The myth's misogyny is structural. Man is the Promethean thief who appropriates divine power; woman is the gift sent in revenge. The Renaissance celebration of human self-fashioning in Pico della Mirandola's *Oration* (1486), Goethe's defiant ode "Prometheus," and Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus* (1818) inherited the Promethean side of the myth, and its gendering largely went unexamined.

The Handmaiden reverses Hesiod. Hideko was a gift in the most exact sense, a commodity offered to collectors as a voice and destined as a bride for whichever man secured her. She becomes a thief. Kleptopoiesis is a feminist Prometheanism: woman not as the gift sent to punish man's theft but as the thief of the fire that men had hoarded.

12.4 *Upāya*: the virtuous lie

Kant's essay "On a Supposed Right to Lie from Philanthropy" (1797) denied that one may lie even to a murderer who asks where one's friend is hiding. By Kant's standard, nearly every act of the film's heroines is impermissible. The women lie to each other, to the men, to the asylum, and to the inn. A Kantian ethics cannot accommodate them.

The Buddhist doctrine of *upāya*, skillful means, can. In the parable of the burning house in the third chapter of the *Lotus Sutra*, a father whose children are absorbed in play inside a burning house lures them out by promising carts drawn by goats, deer, and oxen, and then gives them something finer than he promised. The deception is justified by the liberation it achieves. The women's lies are *upāya*. Each deceives the other in ways that end by leading the beloved out of a burning house, the estate whose order was consuming them both. What distinguishes the virtuous lie from the con is not the falsity of the statements but the direction of the deception: toward the other's freedom or toward her capture.

12.5 Withdrawing service: La Boétie

Étienne de La Boétie's *Discourse on Voluntary Servitude*, written in the mid-sixteenth century, asked why multitudes obey a single tyrant who has no power except what they give him. His answer was that tyranny rests on the habituated consent of the governed, and that it would collapse, like a colossus whose base has been removed, if they simply ceased to serve; no violence would be required. Kouzuki's power over Hideko depended on her voluntary servitude, the self-surveillance the library had trained into her. Fujiwara's plan depended on Sook-hee's service. The decisive political act in the film is a withdrawal of service. When the two servants—the maid and the lady who was the library's servant—stop serving, the edifice falls.

La Boétie was also Montaigne's friend, and their friendship is the subject of Montaigne's "Of Friendship." The two texts that bound the two men, a treatise against servitude and an essay on friendship, converge in the film on two women. Montaigne judged women's souls not firm enough to sustain that bond. The film refutes him with his own formula.

12.6 The Magnificat

The handmaiden has an older theological meaning. In the Gospel of Luke, Mary answers the angel by naming herself the handmaid of the Lord, and her song, the Magnificat, praises a God who has regarded the low estate of his handmaiden, put down the mighty from their seats, and exalted those of low degree (Luke 1:38, 46–55). Liberation theology, from Gustavo Gutiérrez's *A Theology of Liberation* (1971) onward, read the Magnificat as a hymn of social reversal. The film secularizes it. The lowly exalt themselves, the mighty fall by their own instruments, and the handmaiden's song is the sound of bells.

12.7 The criminal relation

Stefano Harney and Fred Moten's *The Undercommons* (2013), working from the Black radical tradition, argued that the only possible relation to the modern university is a criminal one: to steal from it, to study in its margins, and to refuse its professionalization. The concept is rooted in a specific history of fugitivity and is invoked here as a structural analogy, not an equivalence. The women's relation to the library is criminal in this sense. They steal its knowledge, empty its treasury, and destroy its holdings, in order to study each other in a space the institution cannot reach.

12.8 Mimicry versus kleptopoiesis

The film's men are mimics and its women are kleptopoets, and the difference is the center of the theory. Bhabha's colonial mimicry is involuntary in its subversion; it menaces authority through an excess the mimic does not control (Bhabha 1984). Kouzuki and Fujiwara steal identities in order to become the original: the Japanese gentleman, the Japanese count. Their theft confirms the authority of what they counterfeit, and it destroys them. The women steal in order to abolish the original's authority. They do not wish to become the master, the husband, or the Japanese aristocrat. They wish to be free of all three, and they use the stolen instruments to that end. Mimicry steals the form of power and is consumed by it; kleptopoiesis steals the instruments of power and changes their use.



Chapter 13

Fiduciary Eros

Truth After the Gold Standard of Genealogy

13.1 The insolvency of the general equivalents

Goux's *Symbolic Economies* (1973; English translation 1990) proposed that the history of value in the West is organized by a series of general equivalents: in the economic order gold, the commodity that measures all commodities; in kinship the father; in sexuality the phallus; in politics the monarch; in signification language. Each emerges from the group it measures and is set apart as the standard of all the others. *The Coiners of Language* (1984) argued that the end of gold convertibility coincided with a crisis of representation in literature and the arts. When money ceases to be backed by metal, the novel ceases to be backed by a stable referent.

In *The Handmaiden*, every general equivalent is counterfeit. The fortune passes by fraud. The father is a guardian who has groomed his ward since childhood in order to marry her, an incestuous parody of paternity. The phallus is reduced to auditory voyeurism in Kouzuki and to a useless relic in Fujiwara. The monarch appears as an empire mimicked by a collaborator and as a title impersonated by a swindler. Language is forged in the library's editions and accented in the actors' mouths. The film's world is insolvent.

13.2 1931

Britain abandoned the gold standard in September 1931, Japan followed in December under Takahashi Korekiyo, and the United States suspended convertibility in 1933. In those years money became openly fiduciary. Its value no longer rested on a metallic substance but on trust—in issuing states, in institutions, and in the willingness of others to accept it. The film's period makes legible a transformation the film transposes to the erotic: the passage

from a metallic economy of value, in which worth is guaranteed by an origin, to a fiduciary economy, in which worth is constituted by trust. Genealogy is the gold standard of identity. It guarantees who one is by appeal to a substance—blood, birth, lineage—that exists before and outside any relation. The film abolishes that standard and puts nothing in its place except the promise of two persons to each other.

13.3 Confidence

Melville's *The Confidence-Man* (1857) understood that the con is the dark double of fiduciary society. The confidence man exploits confidence—trust, credit, faith—which is also the medium of all commerce, so that a society that runs on trust is a society that can be swindled. *The Handmaiden* begins inside this logic: every relation in it is a confidence game. It ends by redeeming the term. The women's love is confidence in the full sense, a trust that no guarantee can secure and that is honored nonetheless. The con is converted into confidence.

13.4 Fidelity to the event

Alain Badiou's *Being and Event* (1988) defines a truth as the process by which a subject, faithful to an event that the existing situation cannot name, transforms that situation. Love is one of his four truth procedures, alongside politics, art, and science. In *In Praise of Love* (2009), he described love as the construction of a world from the point of view of Two rather than One: an encounter, which is pure chance, followed by a fidelity, which converts chance into a durable truth. He criticized the contemporary fantasy of a love without risk.

The women's encounter could hardly be more aleatory or more compromised. It is produced by a con, arranged by a swindler, and premised on mutual deception. Its truth is not given by its origin, which is a lie, but constituted by fidelity: the decision of each woman to persist in what the encounter revealed. This is the structure of **fiduciary eros**. Its value is not inherited from its beginning. It is minted by the fidelity that follows.

13.5 Promise, forgiveness, friendship, dignity

Arendt described promises as islands of predictability in an ocean of uncertainty, and forgiveness as the faculty that releases actors from the consequences of what they have done (Arendt 1958). Together they constitute fiduciary relations among persons. Montaigne's friendship with La Boétie rested on nothing outside itself and was explained only by the identities of the friends. Kant's *Groundwork* (1785) distinguished things that have a price, which can be replaced by an equivalent, from persons who have dignity, which admits

no equivalent.

These elements compose the film's fiduciary eros, whose movement is from price to dignity. Hideko's voice had a price, her marriage a price, Sook-hee's service a fee; every person in the film's economy was exchangeable for an equivalent. In their love, each woman becomes for the other what has no equivalent. Dignity in this account is not a property inherent in the person and recognized by the other. It is a status the persons confer on each other by refusing equivalence.

13.6 Authentic love and the lesbian choice

Beauvoir's chapter "The Woman in Love" in *The Second Sex* (1949) criticized the love in which a woman abdicates her freedom to a man she makes into her god, and imagined an authentic love founded on the mutual recognition of two freedoms. Her chapter on the lesbian refused both pathology and essentialism, treating lesbianism as a way of assuming one's situation. *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947) argued that my freedom requires the freedom of others. The film realizes Beauvoir's authentic love between two women, each of whose freedom had been designed to be sacrificed to the other's capture.

13.7 The excision of the birth-secret

The hinge of the argument is Park's single most consequential departure from Waters: the removal of the maternal revelation. In *Fingersmith* the sensational truth is genealogical—who bore whom, which infant was exchanged for which—and identity is resolved by the disclosure of origin. Park's film has no such disclosure. The den's matriarch is not secretly anyone's mother, and Hideko and Sook-hee are not secretly anyone's daughters. Who they are is not discovered. It is made.

Foucault's "Nietzsche, Genealogy, History" (1971) distinguished genealogy as a critical method, attentive to descent and emergence, from the metaphysical search for an origin, an essence awaiting discovery. The film dramatizes emergence against origin. Freud's "Family Romances" (1909) described the child's fantasy of nobler parents, the wish to have been born otherwise. Fujiwara and Kouzuki live colonial family romances, wishing to have been born Japanese, aristocratic, legitimate. Sook-hee's pride in a mother remembered as a thief is an inverted family romance. The women end the family romance by ceasing to ask about birth at all.

Goethe's *Elective Affinities* (1809) borrowed a term from chemistry to describe attractions that dissolve existing bonds and form new ones. Kath Weston's *Families We Choose* (1991) documented queer kinship built by election

rather than descent, and Butler's "Is Kinship Always Already Heterosexual?" (2002) challenged the presumption that legitimate kinship must be reproductive. The film's final household belongs to this lineage of elective kinship.

13.8 The second forgery

The film's thesis can now be stated in full. In a world in which every guarantee has been counterfeited, two responses are inadequate: the restoration of an authentic origin, which no longer exists, and resignation to the counterfeit, which leaves its masters in place. A third response is available, **the second forgery**. The women counterfeit the counterfeiters. They forge a madness, a marriage, an identity, and a plot, and in doing so they forge a bond whose value is backed by nothing but itself. The second forgery differs from the first not in being less false but in knowing itself as fiat. It claims no origin; it claims a promise. It is the only honest thing in the film because it is the only forgery that does not pretend to be an original.



Chapter 14

The Counterfeit Commons and Post-Genealogical Humanism

14.1 Humanism's genealogical bias

Humanism has repeatedly grounded dignity in an origin. Renaissance humanism celebrated the self-fashioning creature placed at the center of creation; Enlightenment humanism grounded dignity in a rational nature shared by all; nineteenth-century humanisms grounded it in species-being or national spirit. In practice each of these grounds was genealogical. The Man of humanism was a figure with a lineage: male, European, propertied, legitimate. Sylvia Wynter (2003) argued that this genre of the human, which she named Man, has been overrepresented as if it were the human itself. Fanon closed *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) by calling on the colonized to abandon Europe's model and work out a new humanism. Said's *Humanism and Democratic Criticism* (2004) defended a critical humanism purged of imperial complacency. Paul Gilroy's *Against Race* (2000) proposed a planetary humanism beyond racial thinking, and Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013) argued that critical theory must move beyond humanism's unitary subject altogether.

The Handmaiden contributes to this debate a humanism that is neither restored nor abandoned but ungrounded. Dignity in the film is located neither in nature nor in reason nor in species, and certainly not in lineage. It is minted, in the capacity of persons to make and keep promises to one another. I call this **post-genealogical humanism**.

14.2 The counterfeit commons

The **counterfeit commons** is the social space that such a humanism opens. It is constituted by those who have no legitimate origin in the order around them: the colonized, who are subjects without citizenship; the orphan heiress, whose

inheritance is a curse; the servant, whose name is replaced; the thief, whose livelihood is illegal; the lesbian, whose love has no legal form. Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri's *Commonwealth* (2009) argued that the common is not a natural given but a product, continually made through shared activity. The counterfeit commons is made in this sense. It is counterfeit because it bears no state's stamp, no nation's authorization, no legal title. It is a commons because it is shared. The plan is collective—the den takes part in Sook-hee's rescue—and the fortune leaves the collaborator's estate for two women who belonged to no one's dynasty.

The commons is also minimal. Its core is a society of two, and its periphery is a den of thieves. Chapter 15 considers whether so small a commons deserves the name. Here it suffices to note that the film presents it not as an institution but as an opening: a demonstration that persons without origin can make a world.

14.3 East Asian humanisms

The film engages East Asian humanisms as directly as Western ones. Confucian *ren*, humaneness, was articulated through the three bonds that ordered social life—ruler and subject, father and son, husband and wife—and through the three obediences prescribed to women, to father, husband, and son in turn. Neo-Confucian instruction for women codified these duties: Queen Sohye's *Naehun* (Instructions for Women, 1475) in Korea and the *Onna daigaku* (Greater Learning for Women, 1716), attributed to Kaibara Ekiken, in Japan. Modern states recast them as the ideal of the good wife and wise mother, *ryōsai kenbo* in Japan and *hyeonmo yangcheo* in Korea. The film dissolves all three bonds. The colonial ruler is mimicked and evaded; the father is a predatory guardian; the husband is a swindler. Its heroines obey no one in turn.

The film nonetheless retains the core of Confucian humanism in its Mencian form. As Chapter 8 argued, the rescue at the tree is a Mencian event, the spontaneous emergence of compassion. *Ren* survives the dissolution of the bonds that once housed it.

Korea's own modern humanist tradition supplies a further precedent. Choe Je-u founded Donghak, Eastern Learning, in 1860, teaching that each person bears the Lord of Heaven within. His successor Choe Si-hyeong taught that people should be served as Heaven, and the later Cheondogyo formulated the principle *innaecheon*, that the human being is Heaven. Choe Je-u is remembered for freeing two enslaved women in his household, adopting one as his daughter and taking the other as his daughter-in-law. Donghak's equation of the servant with Heaven, and its translation into the elevation of enslaved women into kin,

is the closest native anticipation of the film's exaltation of the handmaiden.

14.4 Education reversed

Wollstonecraft's *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) argued that women's apparent frivolity and dependence were products of a corrupt education designed to make them pleasing to men, and that rational education would make them free. Hideko's case exceeds that critique. What Kouzuki called her education was the sexual exploitation of a child, years of compelled recitation of pornography before adult men enforced by fear, and it pursued by abuse the end Wollstonecraft diagnosed in ordinary schooling: a woman made pleasing to men. The film answers with a reciprocal education. Sook-hee teaches Hideko touch, care, and the possibility of being loved without being priced. Hideko teaches Sook-hee to read the world's malice, including her own. Neither is master. The education that frees is mutual.

14.5 Natality without mother

Arendt's concept of natality holds that the capacity to begin something new, which grounds action, is rooted in the fact of birth: each person is a beginning (Arendt 1958). The film's ending is a second birth without a mother, natality detached from genealogy. The women begin again, not by being born to someone but by beginning with someone. This is the strongest sense in which the film's humanism is post-genealogical. It locates the human capacity for beginning not in the fact of birth but in the act of election.

14.6 The conjuncture of 2016

The film appeared at a turning point in South Korean feminism. The online community Megalia, founded in 2015, practiced mirroring, turning misogynist speech back against men. In May 2016, the month of the film's Cannes premiere, the murder of a young woman in a restroom near Gangnam Station by a man who said he had been ignored by women provoked mass mourning and protest. In October 2016 Cho Nam-joo published *Kim Ji-young, Born 1982*, which became the decade's defining feminist novel. The Escape the Corset movement of 2018 rejected compulsory beauty labor, and the 4B movement, articulated from around 2019, refused marriage, childbirth, dating, and sex with men.

The film did not cause these developments, and reading it as their source would be an anachronism. It shares their conjuncture. Its narrative form is a mirroring; its heroine sheds the gloves and the gowns of her training; its ending refuses marriage and childbirth and leaves men behind. It gave the period's emerging feminist ethic a narrative image before that ethic had fully named

itself.

14.7 Three tenets

Post-genealogical humanism can be summarized in three tenets. First, value is minted, not inherited: dignity is conferred by persons on one another through fidelity, not discovered as a property of origin. Second, the subject is elected, not descended: who one is is determined by whom one chooses and by what one does with that choice, not by birth. Third, the commons is forged, not found: shared worlds are made by those without legitimate claim to the existing one, using the instruments of that world against its design.



Chapter 15

Objections, Limits, and Counter-Readings

A theory that claims as much as this one must be tested against the strongest objections. Six are considered here.

15.1 The male gaze, again

The first objection holds that a male director cannot film lesbian sex without reproducing the male gaze, and that the film's critique of voyeurism is an alibi for its own. Chapter 5 offered five considerations in reply: the diegetic indictment of spectatorship, the co-authorship of the screenplay, the transformation of meaning through replay, the absence of diegetic witnesses to the women's pleasure, and the interruption of spectacle by speech. These considerations do not dissolve the objection. The camera remains a camera, the film was marketed partly through its eroticism, and some spectators will consume it as the collectors consumed Hideko. The honest conclusion is that the film's reflexivity does not exonerate it. It makes its own complicity visible and invites the spectator to judge, and whether that suffices is a question each viewing reopens.

15.2 Colonial chic

The second objection concerns aesthetics. The film's lavish production design risks converting the colonial period into décor, as part of a wider cycle of Korean films—*Modern Boy* (2008), *Assassination* (2015), *The Age of Shadows* (2016)—that has made colonial Gyeongseong an object of stylish nostalgia. The reply is that the film's décor is diegetically indicted. The house is a collaborator's fantasy, and its beauty is presented as the taste of a man who despised his own nation; the aesthetic is the villain's. The concession is that a diegetic indictment cannot prevent spectators from enjoying the décor as chic.

A critique conducted through beauty remains exposed to the beauty it criticizes.

15.3 Capital

The third objection is Marxist and the most serious. The women escape with Hideko's fortune. Their emancipation is purchased with inherited capital, and their commons of two is a privatized exit rather than a social transformation. Nancy Fraser's "Feminism, Capitalism and the Cunning of History" (2009) argued that second-wave feminism's critiques of the family wage and of state paternalism were absorbed into neoliberal individualism, so that women's liberation came to mean the freedom of some women to compete in markets. The ending of *The Handmaiden* could be read as a fable of this kind.

The reply has three parts. The fortune is expropriated from a design that would have transferred it to a collaborator, so its flight from the estate is a redistribution, however small. The den shares in the rescue and, implicitly, in its proceeds. And the film's utopia is presented as a horizon in Muñoz's sense, not as a program. The concession is that the film offers no social program, that its commons is minimal, and that its happiness is available to these two women because one of them is rich. Kleptopoiesis is a theory of emancipation under conditions in which collective transformation is foreclosed. It is not a substitute for collective transformation.

15.4 Madness as device

The fourth objection comes from disability studies. The asylum's inmates appear as a crowd, a backdrop of suffering against which the heroine's sanity is defined, and madness functions as a plot device and a metaphor for oppression. Susan Sontag's *Illness as Metaphor* (1978) warned against the moralizing use of illness as a figure. The film does not escape this criticism. Its interest is in wrongful confinement, which presupposes a rightful one it does not examine. The women leave the asylum, and the asylum remains.

15.5 National representation

The fifth objection concerns Japan. The film associates Japanese erotic art, the Japanese language, and Japanese aristocratic forms with a regime of perversion, and it may be read as an orientalizing or Korean-nationalist depiction of Japan. The reply is that perversion in the film belongs to the collaborator's mimicry rather than to Japanese culture as such; that its heroine is Japanese and is the agent of emancipation; and that Japanese erotic art is presented not as intrinsically corrupt but as captured by a proprietary archive. The concession is that the film's ero-guro iconography draws on a long Western and Korean

tradition of exoticizing Japanese sexuality, and that its playful use of that tradition does not neutralize it.

15.6 The seduction of the reparative

The sixth objection is methodological and applies to this thesis. Rita Felski's *The Limits of Critique* (2015) urged a postcritical turn toward attachment and affirmation. A reparative reading of a film that ends in joy risks reproducing the film's seduction, assembling its pleasures into a theory that confirms them. The risk is real. This thesis has tried to meet it by keeping the film's critics inside its argument. It acknowledges, finally, that it is itself a second forgery: an interpretation assembled from concepts taken from many traditions and refunctioned to purposes their authors did not intend. Its truth, like the women's, is fiduciary. It is offered on trust.



Conclusion

From the Tolling Bell to the Ringing Bells

Vertigo ends in a bell tower. Judy, the working-class woman whom Gavin Elster made into an impersonation of his wealthy wife and whom Scottie then remade into the dead Madeleine, has been dragged up the stairs of the mission tower at San Juan Bautista. A dark figure rises from the stairwell; startled, Judy steps back and falls. The figure is a nun, who rings the bell. The bell tolls over the substituted woman's body. The substitution plot, the male gaze that sustains it, and the woman made fungible within it terminate in death and in a sound addressed to the dead.

The Handmaiden ends on a ship. The substituted woman and the lady she was hired to replace, having refused the plot that made them interchangeable, lie together in a cabin, and the silver bells ring with their pleasure. No one watches them but the camera, which keeps its distance. The bells do not toll. They ring.

The distance between those two sounds measures the argument of this thesis. Park inherited from Collins, Hitchcock, and Waters a plot in which a woman is substituted for another woman by men who require one of them to disappear. He transposed it into a colonial world in which every guarantee of value—genealogy, nation, title, authorship, virginity, sanity, name—had been counterfeited. He then showed two women stealing the instruments of their own exchange and refunctioning them into a life.

The thesis has argued six propositions. First, the film depicts a single economy of the counterfeit, in which colonial mimicry, the traffic in women, and the pornographic archive are homologous operations governed by the fungibility of persons. Second, it rejects the restoration of origin as a path to freedom; its decisive adaptive act, the excision of the maternal birth-secret, removes the genre's last appeal to genealogical truth. Third, its heroines emancipate themselves through kleptopoiesis, the theft and refunctioning of the apparatuses of their subjection. Fourth, the truth their bond produces is fiduciary, backed by promise, forgiveness, and fidelity rather than origin: a

second forgery that knows itself as fiat. Fifth, their bond opens a counterfeit commons and discloses a post-genealogical humanism, in which dignity is minted through election. Sixth, the film relocates the sensory ground of emancipation from eye and text to hand and bell, converting the frenzy of the visible into a frenzy of the audible.

These propositions contribute to several fields at once. To film-philosophy they offer an account of how narrative structure—refocalization, replay, the withholding of a final twist—can perform a philosophical argument about skepticism and acknowledgment. To adaptation studies they offer a case in which infidelity to a source is thematically motivated: the film is unfaithful to Waters in the way its heroines are unfaithful to their scripts. To transnational feminist and queer theory they offer a model of alliance across the colonial line that refuses the nationalist allegory of the violated woman, and that answers Spivak's critique of feminist individualism from within a plot. To the comparative history of humanism they offer a synthesis of European, Korean, Japanese, and Chinese traditions—from La Boétie and Montaigne to Mencius, the Four–Seven Debate, and Donghak—around a humanism grounded in election rather than descent.

Further research is indicated in three directions. The first is Park's own oeuvre, particularly *Decision to Leave* (2022), which may be read as this film's tragic counterpart: a story of a foreign woman, a detective's gaze, and a language mediated by translation, which ends not in passage across the sea but with a woman burying herself in the sand as the tide comes in. The second is the comparative study of East Asian cinemas of the colonial period, where the question of whether alliance across the colonial line can be represented without nationalist allegory remains open. The third is theoretical. The concepts proposed here—kleptopoiesis, fiduciary eros, the counterfeit commons—require testing against other bodies of work in which the subordinated appropriate the instruments of their subordination.

The film's last image is also its last argument. A plot that began with a theft ends with a gift, and a world in which everything was counterfeit ends with a sound that need not prove anything to anyone. Its heroines do not recover an original. They make something that never existed, and they make it from stolen materials. The bell in *Vertigo* answered the question of what becomes of a woman who is made into a copy: she falls. The bells in *The Handmaiden* answer the same question otherwise. She finds the other copy, and together they ring.



Glossary of Coined Terms

Anti-Salò. A narrative that reconstructs the Sadean apparatus of the narrating woman in full and then has its narrator walk out of it. Contrast Pasolini's *Salò* (1975), in which tenderness survives only as a fragile gesture within the apparatus.

Bertha plan. The design, inherited from *Jane Eyre* and criticized by Spivak, by which a metropolitan woman's freedom is purchased through the confinement of a colonized woman as mad. It is Hideko's original plan, and its abandonment is the turning point of Part Two.

Comedy of unmarriage. A variant of Cavell's comedy of remarriage in which a couple formed through conversation and mutual education constitutes itself against marriage rather than within it.

Counterfeit commons. The shared world made by persons without legitimate origin in the surrounding order—colonized, orphaned, servile, criminal, queer—bearing no state's stamp and made rather than found.

Dactylic epistemology. Knowledge acquired through the hand—by theft, care, and reciprocal touch—as opposed to the library's knowledge by sight, reading, and appraisal.

Double mimicry. The colonized subject's imitation of a colonizer whose own identity is an imitation of a third power; here, a Korean mimicking a Japan that mimics Britain.

Fiduciary eros. A regime of erotic truth in which the value of a bond is constituted by trust, promise, forgiveness, and fidelity rather than guaranteed by origin, modeled on fiduciary money after the abandonment of the gold standard.

Frenzy of the audible. The conversion of pornography's drive to make female pleasure visible into an event of sound, shared by those who produce it and

addressed to no witness.

Kleptopoiesis. The making of a form of life through the theft and refunctioning of the apparatuses that produced one's subjection; distinguished from revolution, exodus, reform, and mere crime.

Post-genealogical humanism. A humanism that locates dignity neither in nature, reason, species, nor lineage but in the capacity of persons to confer it on one another through election. Its three tenets: value is minted, the subject is elected, the commons is forged.

Second forgery. The counterfeiting of the counterfeit by those subjected to it, producing a bond that claims no origin, knows itself as fiat, and is for that reason honest.



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Keywords

Park Chan-wook
The Handmaiden (*Agassi*)
Sarah Waters
Fingersmith
neo-Victorian adaptation
Female Gothic
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colonial Korea
Japanese imperialism
colonial mimicry
double mimicry
collaboration (*chinilpa*)
national allegory
transnational feminism
lesbian cinema
queer theory
counterplot
traffic in women
homosocial desire
male gaze
masquerade
the female voice
acoustic regimes
haptic visuality
dactylic epistemology
Sade
historienne
libertine pedagogy
ero-guro-nansensu
shunga
Tanizaki Jun'ichirō
archive
pharmakon
forgery
the counterfeit
gold standard
general equivalent
recognition
acknowledgment
skepticism
Hegelian dialectic
promise and forgiveness
Mencius
Four–Seven Debate
Donghak
Confucian humanism
post-genealogical humanism
kleptopoiesis
fiduciary eros
counterfeit commons
second forgery
frenzy of the audible
heterotopia
iconoclasm
feminist sex wars
reparative reading
film-philosophy